LESSON HANDOUT

Lesson 3.1: Doodling a CAT Passage

Control. Let's now control the passage.
Control is everything. Day One was sentences. Day Two was paragraphs. Now, we control the entire passage.

What we learnt so far is simple: A paragraph is not magic; it's just sentences. Every sentence, no matter how annoying it looks, can be reduced to 4–8 words by pulling out the main Subject + Verb + Object/Complement.

Once you do that for every sentence in a paragraph, the paragraph becomes a fight. One idea wins; the rest are staff. That winning idea becomes the main point of the paragraph—the doodle.

Now we do the exact same thing... one level up.

Passage Control = Paragraph Control... repeated
A CAT passage is basically a stack of paragraphs. Roughly 500 words. Now watch the process:

1. **Doodle Paragraph 1** (4–8 words)
2. **Doodle Paragraph 2** (4–8 words)
3. **Doodle Paragraph 3** (4–8 words)
4. **Doodle Paragraph 4** (4–8 words)
5. **Doodle Paragraph 5** (4–8 words)
6. **Doodle Paragraph 6** (4–8 words)

Now you have 6 doodles. And the same rule applies again: **One of these paragraph-doodles is the hero.** The others are just doing jobs:

- Context
- Counterview
- Support for counterview
- Rebuttal
- Support for author's rebuttal
- Nuance / conclusion

Yes, even a passage can be reduced to 4–8 words. Not because we are geniuses, but because your brain cannot store 500 words anyway. *Stop pretending you will.*

"Sir, are we discarding 475 words? Isn't that dangerous?"

Two things:

1. **500 words cannot exist in your head.**
   So "remember everything" is not a strategy. It's a hallucination.
2. If a question forces you back into the passage, you won't be lost.
   Because you know the **structure**.

If the question is about:

- the counterview: you know which paragraph it was
- the rebuttal: you know where it happened
- the support: you know where it lives

This is like watching a movie. You don't remember every dialogue. You remember the story. That is enough.

LESSON HANDOUT

Demonstration Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 3

- **Source**: *Humankind: A Hopeful History by Rutger Bregman review – a tribute to our better nature by Andrew Anthony*, The Guardian
- **Stats**: 517 Words | 24 Sentences | 21.5 Words/Sentence | 6 Paragraphs | 11.7 Flesch Kincaid Grade Level

We will do this slowly, paragraph by paragraph.
Your only job here is to see the **control method**, not speed.

The Passage (6 paragraphs) and the Doodles
Paragraph 1 (Context setup)
Text
Although one of the most contested concepts in political philosophy, human nature is something on which most people seem to agree. By and large, according to Rutger Bregman in his new book Humankind, we have a rather pessimistic view—not of ourselves exactly, but of everyone else. We see other people as selfish, untrustworthy and dangerous and therefore we behave towards them with defensiveness and suspicion. This was how the 17th-century philosopher Thomas Hobbes conceived our natural state to be, believing that all that stood between us and violent anarchy was a

- the rebuttal: you know where it happened
- the support: you know where it lives

This is like watching a movie. You don't remember every dialogue. You remember the story. That is enough.

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The Passage (6 paragraphs) and the Doodles

Paragraph 1 (Context setup)

Text

Although one of the most contested concepts in political philosophy, human nature is something on which most people seem to agree. By and large, according to Rutger Bregman in his new book Humankind, we have a rather pessimistic view—not of ourselves exactly, but of everyone else. We see other people as selfish, untrustworthy and dangerous and therefore we behave towards them with defensiveness and suspicion. This was how the 17th-century philosopher Thomas Hobbes conceived our natural state to be, believing that all that stood between us and violent anarchy was a strong state and firm leadership.

- **What's happening:** "Although" tells you concession, but nothing explosive yet. The job is to establish the common, pessimistic view (Hobbes-style).
- **Main Point: People assume others are selfish/dangerous.**
- **Role:** Context: the default pessimistic view.

People: others dangerous (Hobbes)

Paragraph 2 (Bregman's correction)

Text

But in following Hobbes, argues Bregman, we ensure that the negative view we have of human nature is reflected back at us. He instead puts his faith in Jean-Jacques Rousseau, the 18th-century French thinker, who famously declared that man was born free and it was civilisation—with its coercive powers, social classes and restrictive laws — that put him in chains.

- **What's happening:** Now we get the **BUT**. This is the shift. Bregman says pessimism is self-fulfilling and sides with Rousseau: civilisation is the villain.
- **Doodle: Bregman blames civilisation, not human nature.**
- **Role:** Counterview/alternative frame introduced.

Bregman: Civilization ~~=~~ problem!

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Paragraph 3 (Bregman's support story)

Text

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LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 3 (Bregman's support story)
Text
Hobbes and Rousseau are seen as the two poles of the human nature argument and it's no surprise that Bregman strongly sides with the Frenchman. He takes Rousseau's intuition and paints a picture of a prelapsarian idyll in which, for the better part of 300,000 years, Homo sapiens lived a fulfilling life in harmony with nature . . . Then we discovered agriculture and for the next 10,000 years it was all property, war, greed and injustice. . . .

- **What's happening:** Bregman builds a narrative: pre-agriculture = harmony; agriculture = corruption.
- **Doodle: Pre-agriculture harmony; agriculture created corruption.**
- **Role:** Support for Bregman's stance.



Paragraph 4 (Author enters: "This may be true, but...")
Text
It was abandoning our nomadic lifestyle and then domesticating animals, says Bregman, that brought about infectious diseases such as measles, smallpox, tuberculosis, syphilis, malaria, cholera and plague. This may be true, but what Bregman never really seems to get to grips with is that pathogens were not the only things that grew with agriculture—so did the number of humans. It's one thing to maintain friendly relations and a property-less mode of living when you're 30 or 40 hunter-gatherers following the food. But life becomes a great deal more complex and knowledge far more extensive when there are settlements of many thousands.
This paragraph is the turn.

- **What's happening:** This is the **TURN**. The author steps in. "This may be true, but..." Agriculture brought diseases, yes, but it also brought complexity and population growth. The author isn't buying the clean villain story.
- **Doodle: Agriculture increased population, complexity, knowledge.**
- **Role:** Rebuttal/nuance: Bregman's story is incomplete.



Paragraph 5 (Another Bregman claim + author's moderation)
Text
"Civilisation has become synonymous with peace and progress and wilderness with war and decline," writes Bregman. "In reality, for most of human existence, it was the other way around." Whereas traditional history depicts the collapse of civilisations as "dark ages" in which everything gets worse, modern scholars, he claims, see them more as a reprieve, in which the enslaved gain their freedom and culture flourishes. Like much else in this book, the truth is probably somewhere between the two stated positions.

- **What's happening:** Bregman claims we reversed reality. The author taps the table: *"The truth is probably somewhere between."* That is the author's personality.
- **Doodle: Civilisation vs wilderness: truth lies between.**
- **Role:** Author's moderation: refuses extreme binaries.



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Paragraph 6 (Concession + final punch)
Text
In any case, the fear of civilisational collapse, Bregman believes, is unfounded. It's the result of what the Dutch biologist Frans de Waal calls "veneer theory"—the idea that just below the surface, our bestial nature is waiting to

- **Role:** Author's moderation: refuses extreme binaries.

Author : Truth lies between [Civ(good) — Civ(bad)]

LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 6 (Concession + final punch)
Text

In any case, the fear of civilisational collapse, Bregman believes, is unfounded. It's the result of what the Dutch biologist Frans de Waal calls "veneer theory"—the idea that just below the surface, our bestial nature is waiting to break out. . . . There's a great deal of reassuring human decency to be taken from this bold and thought-provoking book and a wealth of evidence in support of the contention that the sense of who we are as a species has been deleteriously distorted. But it seems equally misleading to offer the false choice of Rousseau and Hobbes when, clearly, humanity encompasses both.

- **What's happening:** Bregman says we are decent. The author concedes the book is bold, but lands the final kill: Stop treating humans as either angels OR animals. Reality is both.
- **Doodle: False Hobbes vs Rousseau choice; both true.**
- **Role:** Conclusion: nuanced middle position.

Author : (Hobbes (new) + Rousseau (new)) → Both exist

The 6 doodles together (the 25-word story)

P1: People/Hobbes → others seen dangerous
P2: Bregman → civilisation creates the problem
P3: Bregman → pre-agri harmony, agri problems
P4: Author → population & complexity matter
P5: Author → truth lies between extremes
P6: Author → Hobbes + Rousseau both valid

That's the passage in your head.
Not 517 words.
Not 24 sentences.
Six small hooks.

What is the passage REALLY doing?

Now we stop pretending that all paragraphs are equal.
The passage's structure is:

- Set up pessimistic default (Hobbes)
- Present Bregman's alternative (Rousseau)
- Give Bregman's romantic story of decline
- Author pushes back: complexity and population
- Author says: truth isn't at extremes
- Author concludes: Hobbes and Rousseau both matter

So the **main point of the passage** is not "Bregman says humans are good".
The main point is: Bregman offers a clean Rousseau story, but the reviewer insists reality sits between Rousseau and Hobbes.
That is the hero.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Now see why questions become easy

- Author concludes: Hobbes and Rousseau both matter

So the **main point of the passage** is not "Bregman says humans are good".
The main point is: Bregman offers a clean Rousseau story, but the reviewer insists reality sits between Rousseau and Hobbes.
That is the hero.

LESSON HANDOUT

Now see why questions become easy
Because CAT questions are not asking "remember line 73".
They are asking: do you know the **structure**?
And you do.

Question 1
The author has differing views from Bregman regarding:
1. the role of pathogens in the spread of infectious diseases
2. a civilised society being coercive and unjust
3. a property-less mode of living being socially harmonious
4. the role of agriculture in the advancement of knowledge

Step 1: What is the question REALLY asking?
Not:
- what did Bregman say?
- what facts appear?

But:
Where does the author disagree with Bregman?
So we immediately go to:
- Paragraphs **4, 5, 6**
- Author-entry zones

Option-by-option Rip
Option 1: pathogens and diseases
Bregman says agriculture brought diseases.
Author explicitly says: "*This may be true...*"
So the author **agrees**, not disagrees.
❌ Kill.

Option 2: civilised society being coercive and unjust
This is Bregman's **core claim** (Paragraphs 2–3).
Author spends the rest of the passage **softening, nuancing, rejecting the clean blame**.
This is the **central disagreement**.
✅ Keep.

Option 3: property-less mode of living being harmonious
Author explicitly says:
"It's one thing to maintain friendly relations when you're 30–40 hunter-gatherers..."
That is a **concession**.
Agreement, not disagreement.
❌ Kill.

Option 4: agriculture advancing knowledge
Author explicitly says:
"knowledge far more extensive when there are settlements of many thousands"
That's the author's addition, not a disagreement.
❌ Kill.

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 2**

Author explicitly says:
"It's one thing to maintain friendly relations when you're 30–40 hunter-gatherers..."
That is a **concession**.
Agreement, not disagreement.
❌ Kill.

Option 4: agriculture advancing knowledge
Author explicitly says:
"knowledge far more extensive when there are settlements of many thousands"
That's the author's addition, not a disagreement.
❌ Kill.

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 2**

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Question 2
According to the passage, the 'collapse of civilisations' is viewed by Bregman as:
1. a sign of regression in society's trajectory
2. resulting from a breakdown in the veneer of human nature
3. a time that enables changes in societies and cultures
4. a temporary phase which can be rectified by social action

Step 1: Whose view?
The question says **"viewed by Bregman"**.
So we **ignore the author's moderation**.
Go straight to **Paragraph 5**.

Option-by-option Rip
Option 1: sign of regression
Opposite of what Bregman says.
He rejects "dark ages".
❌ Kill.

Option 2: veneer theory breakdown
Veneer theory explains fear of collapse, not collapse itself.
Wrong logic.
❌ Kill.

Option 3: enables changes in societies and cultures
Matches:
"a reprieve, in which the enslaved gain their freedom and culture flourishes"
Exact alignment.
✅ Keep.

Option 4: temporary phase to be rectified
Nowhere does Bregman say it must be "rectified".
Invented purpose.
❌ Kill.

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 3**

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Question 3

None of the following views is expressed in the passage EXCEPT that:

1. Hobbes and Rousseau disagreed on human nature but both believed in a strong state
2. Bregman agrees with Hobbes that firm leadership is needed
3. the author believes in veneer theory
4. most people agree with Hobbes' pessimistic view of human nature

Step 1: Handle the logic trap

"None ... EXCEPT"

= find the **ONE statement that IS expressed**

So we ask:

Which statement is **clearly stated**?

Option-by-option Rip

Option 1: both believed in strong state

Rousseau explicitly rejects coercive civilisation.

False.

❌ Kill.

Option 2: Bregman agrees with Hobbes on firm leadership

Direct contradiction.

❌ Kill.

Option 3: author believes in veneer theory

Veneer theory is attributed to **Frans de Waal**, reported via Bregman.

Author does **not endorse it**.

❌ Kill.

Option 4: most people agree with Hobbes' pessimism

Paragraph 1:

"human nature is something on which most people seem to agree"

"we see others as selfish, untrustworthy and dangerous"

Directly stated.

✅ Keep.

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 4**

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Question 4
According to the author, the main reason why Bregman contrasts life in pre-agricultural societies with agricultural societies is to:

1. advocate promotion of less complex societies
2. bolster his argument that people are basically decent but progress can make them selfish
3. highlight the impact of farming on population growth
4. argue for environmentally conscious lifestyles

Step 1: Whose intent?
The question says:
"why **Bregman** contrasts..."
So we ask:
What was Bregman **trying to prove**?
Not what the author corrected.

Option-by-option Rip
Option 1: advocate less complex societies
Bregman romanticises, but does not prescribe policy.
Overreach.
❌ Kill.

Option 2: bolster argument people are decent, civilisation corrupts
This is **exactly** Paragraphs 2–3.
Core Bregman logic.
✅ Keep.

Option 3: population growth
This is the **author's correction**, not Bregman's intent.
❌ Kill.

Option 4: environmental lifestyle
Never argued.
❌ Kill.

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 2**

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Final Rule (Passage Control)
You **never** solve CAT RC by rereading passages.
You solve it by:

1. Doodling paragraphs (in your head or on paper)
2. Mapping passage roles
3. Ripping options against **the key ideas**

Options die because of:

- scope mismatch
- tone mismatch
- extreme positions
- alien ideas
- lies!
- sidetrack mismatch (true statements that do not answer the question)

In short, S.T.E.A.L.S. We will learn about this later.

This is **full passage control**.

LESSON HANDOUT

Lesson 3.2: Passage Structure

This is where reading really happens

CAT passages are **not random prose**.
They follow **recognisable structures**, depending on **what the author is trying to do**.

In CAT, passages broadly fall into **three structural types**:

1. Expository
2. Analytical
3. Argumentative

These are **not emotional styles**.
They are **ways of organising ideas**.

---

1. EXPOSITORY STRUCTURE
(Knowledge Presenter)
The author's job is simple:

- To **explain X**
- To **present information**
- To stay **neutral**

The author tells you *what something is*, not *what to think about it*.

Expository Structure 1: Feature Listing
Structure

- What is X
- Feature 1 of X
- Feature 2 of X
- Feature 3 of X

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT Reading Comprehension (RC) is designed to test comprehension of unfamiliar, dense material…
…One feature of CAT RCs is their reliance on long, information-heavy passages…
…Another feature is the use of academic or journalistic writing styles…
…A third feature is the emphasis on idea prioritisation…

Expository Structure 2: Definition Structure
Structure

- What is X
- What it refers to
- What it includes
- What it does not include

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RCs refer to passages used to assess reading comprehension…
…They refer to texts drawn from academic, journalistic, or intellectual domains…
…They include dense arguments, unfamiliar topics, and complex sentence structures…
…They do not include questions that rely on prior subject knowledge or factual recall…

LESSON HANDOUT

Expository Structure 3: Classification
Structure

- X as a category
- Type 1
- Type 2
- Key distinction

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RCs can be treated as a category of passages used to test reading comprehension…
…One type focuses on explaining concepts or ideas drawn from academic domains….
…Another type examines relationships, causes, or mechanisms within a topic….
…The key distinction lies in whether the passage explains what something is or how it works….

Expository Structure 4: Historical Description (Origin Story)
Structure

- Origin of X
- Early form

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LESSON HANDOUT

Expository Structure 3: Classification
Structure

- X as a category
- Type 1
- Type 2
- Key distinction

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RCs can be treated as a category of passages used to test reading comprehension…
…One type focuses on explaining concepts or ideas drawn from academic domains….
…Another type examines relationships, causes, or mechanisms within a topic….
…The key distinction lies in whether the passage explains what something is or how it works….

Expository Structure 4: Historical Description (Origin Story)
Structure

- Origin of X
- Early form
- Key development
- Present form

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RCs originated as short comprehension checks in early management tests…
…In their early form, passages were simpler and closer to narrative prose…
…Over time, they incorporated academic writing and abstract argumentation…
…In their present form, CAT RCs test structural reading under time pressure…

Key Difficulty with Expository Passages

- High factual density
- Many details
- No clear author opinion

This makes **doodling harder**, because nothing "stands out emotionally".

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2. ANALYTICAL STRUCTURE
(Knowledge Interpreter)
Here, the author is still **neutral**, but now:

- The author steps **inside X**
- Shows **how things are connected**
- Explains **why something happens**

LESSON HANDOUT

2. ANALYTICAL STRUCTURE
(Knowledge Interpreter)
Here, the author is still **neutral**, but now:

- The author steps **inside X**
- Shows **how things are connected**
- Explains **why something happens**

The shift is:

- Expository → *What is X*
- Analytical → *What is happening with X*

Analytical Structure 1: Problem → Explanation
Structure

- Problem X
- Why it exists
- What sustains it
- What it leads to

Example of Passage Structure
…Many students struggle disproportionately with CAT RCs…
…This difficulty exists because passages are dense and structurally complex…
…It is sustained by habits of reading for detail rather than hierarchy…
…As a result, CAT RCs often lead to misinterpretation and time pressure…

Analytical Structure 2: Condition → Outcome
Structure

- Condition X
- When it exists
- What follows
- Resulting outcome

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RC passages involve abstract academic domains…
…Readers usually approach them without a clear hierarchy of ideas…
…Misreading and loss of control tend to follow…
…The resulting outcome is poor accuracy despite adequate reading speed…

Analytical Structure 3: Cause → Effect
Structure

- X happens
- Reason 1
- Reason 2
- Outcome

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RC passages often overwhelm test-takers…
…One reason is the use of long, syntactically complex sentences…
…Another reason is the presence of multiple competing ideas within a paragraph…
…The outcome is a misinterpretation of the passage's main argument…

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…Another reason is the presence of multiple competing ideas within a paragraph…
…The outcome is a misinterpretation of the passage's main argument…

Analytical Structure 4: Pattern → Reason

Structure

- Repeated pattern
- Underlying cause
- Supporting factor
- What it explains

Example of Passage Structure

…Across multiple CAT attempts, students consistently underperform in RC…
…This repeated pattern is driven by difficulty in handling dense academic prose…
…It is further sustained by reading habits that prioritise detail over structure…
…This explains why RC scores lag despite extensive practice…

Analytical Structure 5: Process

Structure

- Input
- Step 1
- Step 2
- Final result

Example of Passage Structure

…CAT RCs present candidates with dense, unfamiliar passages…
…Readers first decode sentence structure and identify key ideas…
…They then prioritise paragraph-level arguments while discarding detail…
…The final result is accurate comprehension under severe time constraints…

Analytical Structure 6: Comparison

Structure

- X
- Y
- Key difference
- What this explains

Example of Passage Structure

…Some CAT RC passages focus on explaining concepts in a neutral manner…
…Others analyse causes, mechanisms, or implications…
…The key difference lies in whether the passage presents information or interprets it…
…This explains why different RCs demand different reading strategies…

Analytical Structure 7: Evaluation (Neutral)

Structure

- Idea
- Strength
- Weakness
- You decide

Example of Passage Structure

…CAT RCs aim to test comprehension and reasoning through unfamiliar texts…
…A clear strength is their ability to assess idea prioritisation under pressure...
…However, density and abstraction disadvantage some test-takers…
…Whether this balance is appropriate depends on how one defines reading ability…

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- Weakness
- You decide

Example of Passage Structure

…CAT RCs aim to test comprehension and reasoning through unfamiliar texts…
…A clear strength is their ability to assess idea prioritisation under pressure...
…However, density and abstraction disadvantage some test-takers…
…Whether this balance is appropriate depends on how one defines reading ability…

---

3. ARGUMENTATIVE STRUCTURE
(Knowledge Advocate)

Here, the author:

- Takes a **position**
- Defends it with **reasons**
- Wants you to **accept a conclusion**

Neutrality is gone.

Argumentative Structure 1: Claim → Support

Structure

- Claim / Position
- Reason 1
- Reason 2
- Claim restated

Example of Passage Structure

…CAT RCs are a fair and effective test of higher-order reading ability…
…They assess how well candidates prioritise ideas rather than recall facts…
…They mirror real managerial reading demands involving dense material…
…For these reasons, CAT RCs remain a justified core component of the exam…

Argumentative Structure 2: Counter → Rebuttal

Structure

- Opposing view
- Why it fails
- My view
- Reason

Example of Passage Structure

…Some argue that CAT RCs primarily test speed rather than comprehension…
…This view fails to recognise the role of structural reading…
…CAT RCs actually reward readers who identify hierarchy under pressure…
…RC performance reflects reasoning skill, not mere reading speed…

Argumentative Structure 3: Problem → Solution

Structure

- Problem
- Why it matters
- Solution
- What should be done

Example of Passage Structure

…CAT RCs disadvantage students who read carefully but slowly…
…This matters because the section is meant to assess comprehension…
…A better approach would prioritise structural understanding over speed…
…Preparation should focus on idea hierarchy rather than rapid reading…

…CAT RCs actually reward readers who identify hierarchy under pressure…
…RC performance reflects reasoning skill, not mere reading speed…

Argumentative Structure 3: Problem → Solution
Structure

- Problem
- Why it matters
- Solution
- What should be done

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RCs disadvantage students who read carefully but slowly…
…This matters because the section is meant to assess comprehension…
…A better approach would prioritise structural understanding over speed…
…Preparation should focus on idea hierarchy rather than rapid reading…

Argumentative Structure 4: Evaluation (Non-Neutral)
Structure

- Idea
- Strength
- Weakness
- Judgement

Example of Passage Structure
…CAT RCs are designed to assess higher-order reading and reasoning ability…
…Their emphasis on idea hierarchy is a genuine strength…
…Yet excessive density and abstraction undermine fair assessment…
…Overall, CAT RCs fail to measure reading competence as effectively as they claim…

Closing Line (from the lesson)

- Passage structure controls comprehension.
- Paragraphs have jobs.
- Logic moves across paragraphs.
- Author role determines structure.

This is the foundation.
Each structure will be handled in depth next.

LESSON HANDOUT

Lesson 4.1: Doodling Expository Passage

Doodling an Expository CAT Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 1

Before You Start Reading (Read This First)

This lesson has one non-negotiable rule. For every paragraph, you will pick **ONLY ONE** idea.
Not two. Not a combination. Not a "this plus that" Frankenstein sentence. **One idea.**
At this point, a natural worry comes up:

- *"What if I leave the wrong idea?"*
- *"What if I should have picked something else?"*
- *"Can I take two ideas just to be safe?"*

The answer is NO. Do not take multiple ideas. That is where the disaster starts. The moment you begin picking two ideas, you will struggle in every single paragraph because you will keep second-guessing yourself. You'll be standing there like an **Alien** on a new planet, confused about which way to go.
Pick one idea and trust it. Whatever idea you pick, treat it as the key idea and move on. You already have an innate ability to sense what matters in a paragraph. You've been reading since you were a kid—**don't fight your own brain by overthinking.**
Leave things behind:

- names
- examples
- side remarks
- extra classifications

Let's be blunt: That is not carelessness. **That is control.** If a question later demands a specific detail, *The Question Setter* will force you back to the passage. That is expected! That is part of the game. But your job while reading is **not** to be a human database.
Your job is to pick **ONE** idea and keep moving. **That is paragraph control.**

In the previous lesson, we looked at passages based on the purpose of writing:

- **Expository** -> to explain
- **Analytical** -> to analyse
- **Argumentative** -> to argue

Argumentative passages are easy to identify. The author is visible, involved, and defending a position. The real confusion is between expository and analytical. That confusion is normal.

Why? Because both are largely neutral. The author is not sharing personal opinions.

So here is the operating rule: If you cannot clearly distinguish between expository and analytical, *don't overthink it.* Do not waste time. The doodling process is the same.

What matters is the primary intent: **What is the author mainly trying to do?**
In this passage, the author is a knowledge presenter. The job is simple: **explain X.**

LESSON HANDOUT

Demonstration Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 1

- **Source:** *Anarchism: A Very Short Introduction* – Colin Ward
- **Stats:** 493 words | 15 sentences | ~33 words per sentence | 6 paragraphs
- **Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level:** 18.5

Long sentences and big words do not automatically make a passage difficult. **Lack of control does.**

The Passage and the Doodles

Paragraph 1

Text: The word 'anarchy' comes from the Greek *anarkhia*, meaning contrary to authority or without a ruler, and was used in a derogatory sense until 1840, when it was adopted by Pierre-Joseph Proudhon to describe his political and social ideology. Proudhon argued that organization without government was both possible and desirable. In the evolution of political ideas, anarchism can be seen as an ultimate projection of both liberalism and socialism, and the differing strands of anarchist thought can be related to their emphasis on one or the other of these

So here is the operating rule: If you cannot clearly distinguish between expository and analytical, *don't overthink it*. Do not waste time. The doodling process is the same.

What matters is the primary intent: **What is the author mainly trying to do?**
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LESSON HANDOUT

Demonstration Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 1

- **Source:** *Anarchism: A Very Short Introduction* – Colin Ward
- **Stats:** 493 words | 15 sentences | ~33 words per sentence | 6 paragraphs
- **Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level:** 18.5

Long sentences and big words do not automatically make a passage difficult. **Lack of control does.**

The Passage and the Doodles

Paragraph 1

Text: The word 'anarchy' comes from the Greek *anarkhia*, meaning contrary to authority or without a ruler, and was used in a derogatory sense until 1840, when it was adopted by Pierre-Joseph Proudhon to describe his political and social ideology. Proudhon argued that organization without government was both possible and desirable. In the evolution of political ideas, anarchism can be seen as an ultimate projection of both liberalism and socialism, and the differing strands of anarchist thought can be related to their emphasis on one or the other of these.

Explanation This paragraph contains many details: Greek origin, historical usage, Proudhon, liberalism, socialism. *Don't overthink it.* Do not summarise.

Ask one question: **If everything else is removed, what must remain for the paragraph to still make sense?** If you remove:

- the Greek word
- the year
- Proudhon's name
- liberalism and socialism

...the paragraph still survives.

If you remove:

- "organisation without government" It collapses. This paragraph exists to define anarchism.

Doodle: Anarchism = organisation without government

Paragraph 2

Text: Historically, anarchism arose not only as an explanation of the gulf between the rich and the poor in any community, and of the reason why the poor have been obliged to fight for their share of a common inheritance, but as a radical answer to the question 'What went wrong?' that followed the ultimate outcome of the French Revolution. It had ended not only with a reign of terror and the emergence of a newly rich ruling caste, but with a new adored emperor, Napoleon Bonaparte, strutting through his conquered territories.

Explanation: The keyword "Historically" tells you exactly why this paragraph exists. This paragraph explains the origin of anarchism. The French Revolution promised:

- freedom
- end of power What followed:
- terror
- a new ruling class
- an emperor So anarchism emerges as a response to betrayal after revolution.

Doodle: Origin of Anarchism: French Revolution betrayal

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Doodle: Origin of Anarchism: French Revolution betrayal

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Paragraph 3

Text: The anarchists and their precursors were unique on the political Left in affirming that workers and peasants, grasping the chance that arose to bring an end to centuries of exploitation and tyranny, were inevitably betrayed by the new class of politicians, whose first priority was to re-establish a centralized state power. After every revolutionary uprising, usually won at a heavy cost for ordinary populations, the new rulers had no hesitation in applying violence and terror, a secret police, and a professional army to maintain their control.

Explanation: This paragraph generalises the French Revolution. It is no longer one event. It becomes a pattern. Every revolution:

- starts with hope
- ends with new rulers
- recreates power

So anarchists conclude that revolutions do not remove power; they rearrange it.

Doodle Revolutions recreate power

Paragraph 4

Text: For anarchists the state itself is the enemy, and they have applied the same interpretation to the outcome of every revolution of the 19th and 20th centuries. This is not merely because every state keeps a watchful and sometimes punitive eye on its dissidents, but because every state protects the privileges of the powerful.

Explanation: This is the core belief paragraph. Everything before leads here. Everything after depends on this. Why do revolutions fail? **Because the state itself is the problem.** This is explanation, not opinion.

Doodle: Core Belief of Anarchism: State is the enemy

Paragraph 5

Text: The mainstream of anarchist propaganda for more than a century has been anarchist-communism, which argues that property in land, natural resources, and the means of production should be held in mutual control by local communities, federating for innumerable joint purposes with other communes. It differs from state socialism in opposing the concept of any central authority. Some anarchists prefer to distinguish between anarchist-communism and collectivist anarchism in order to stress the obviously desirable freedom of an individual or family to possess the resources needed for living, while not implying the right to own the resources needed by others.

Explanation: Now the author begins classification. This is **Type 1** of anarchism. Key idea:

- resources controlled by local communities
- rejection of central authority Other distinctions are noted but not prioritised.

Don't overthink it unless a question forces you back.

Doodle: Type 1: anarchist communism (local control)

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Paragraph 6

Text: There are, unsurprisingly, several traditions of individualist anarchism, one of them deriving from the 'conscious egoism' of the German writer Max Stirner (1806–56), and another from a remarkable series of 19th-century American figures who argued that in protecting our own autonomy and associating with others for common advantages, we are promoting the good of all. These thinkers differed from free-market liberals in their absolute mistrust of American

Doodle: Type 1: anarchist communism (local control)

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Paragraph 6

Text: There are, unsurprisingly, several traditions of individualist anarchism, one of them deriving from the 'conscious egoism' of the German writer Max Stirner (1806–56), and another from a remarkable series of 19th-century American figures who argued that in protecting our own autonomy and associating with others for common advantages, we are promoting the good of all. These thinkers differed from free-market liberals in their absolute mistrust of American capitalism, and in their emphasis on mutualism.

Explanation: This is **Type 2** of anarchism. Key ideas:

- individual autonomy
- mutualism
- explicit difference from free-market liberals

Names are secondary. *Alien* info for now.

Doodle: Type 2: individualist anarchism (autonomy + mutualism)

Passage Structure (The Doodles)

- What anarchism is (What is X)
- Anarchism Origin: French Revolution betrayal (Origins of X)
- Anarchism Premise: Revolutions betray people (Extension of Origins of X)
- Anarchism Core Idea: State is the enemy (Core of X)
- Type 1: anarchist communism (Type 1 of X)
- Type 2: individualist anarchism (Type 2 of X)

This should be enough to solve the questions.

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QUESTIONS AND OPTION-BY-OPTION EXPLANATIONS

Question 1
Individualist anarchism can be seen as the report of a constructive interaction between 'individual autonomy' and 'mutualism'. Which of the following best describes the difference between individualist anarchists and free-market liberals?

What is this question REALLY asking? This is not asking: "What do anarchists believe?" or "What do liberals believe?" It is asking for a comparison structure: one common ground (Similarity) and one clear separation (Difference). If either half is wrong, the option dies.

What can we anticipate before touching the options? Go to Paragraph 6 only. The differences are explicitly on capitalism and mutualism. Anarchists focus on mutualism; free-market liberals on capitalism. Both likely advocate for autonomy/freedom. The difference is in mutualism: free-market liberalism does not favour mutualism.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option 1:** *Both reject the regulatory power of the state; but the former favour a people's state, while the latter favour state intervention in markets.*
  - **Evaluation: Rotten.** "People's state" is an **Alien** concept—anarchists want no state. Free market liberals wanting "state intervention"? They are capitalists. **100% false.**
  - ❌ **Kill: Invented framework**
- **Option 2:** *Both prioritise individual autonomy, but the former also emphasise mutual dependence, while the latter do not do so.*
  - **Evaluation: Keep.** This fits perfectly. Autonomy is common; "mutual dependence" (mutualism) is the difference explicitly mentioned for American individualist anarchists.
  - ✅ **Keep: Exact structural match**
- **Option 3:** *Both are sophisticated arguments for capitalism; but the former argue for a morally upright capitalism, while the latter argue that the market is the only morality.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** This itself is enough for elimination: the passage says anarchists have "absolute mistrust" of capitalism. **100% false.**
  - ❌ **Kill: Direct contradiction**
- **Option 4:** *Both are founded on the moral principles of altruism; but the latter conceive of the market as a force too mystical for the former to comprehend.*
  - **Evaluation: Alien.** What is this random thing? None of this "altruism" or "mystical market" stuff is in the passage.
  - ❌ **Kill: Alien ideas**

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 2**

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force too mystical for the former to comprehend.

- **Evaluation: Alien.** What is this random thing? None of this "altruism" or "mystical market" stuff is in the passage.
- ❌ **Kill: Alien ideas**

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 2**

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Question 2
The author makes all of the following arguments in the passage, EXCEPT:

What is this question REALLY testing? This is a presence/absence test. Which statement is not true based on the passage?

What can we anticipate before touching the options? This is a hunt for a statement that either contradicts the text or introduces an entirely new, unsupported idea.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option 1:** *Individualist anarchism is actually constituted of many streams, all of which focus on the autonomy of the individual.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Paragraph 6 says "several traditions" and "focus on autonomy." This is a true statement.
  - ❌ **Kill: Clearly stated**
- **Option 2:** *The popular perception of anarchism as espousing lawlessness and violence comes from a mainstream mistrust of collectivism.*
  - **Evaluation: Keep.** Who is mistrusting collectivism? Where is "popular perception" or "lawlessness" mentioned? This is not in the passage. Clean **Alien** idea.
  - ✅ **Keep: Not in passage**
- **Option 3:** *For anarchists, the state is the enemy because all states apply violence and terror to maintain their control.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Extreme statement? Yes. But they are in an extreme position. Paragraphs 3 and 4 explicitly mention violence, terror, and the state as the enemy.
  - ❌ **Kill: Clearly stated**
- **Option 4:** *The failure of the French Revolution was because of its betrayal by the new class of politicians who emerged from it.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Paragraphs 2 and 3 state this very clearly. It is a central argument.
  - ❌ **Kill: Core argument**

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✅ **Correct Answer: Option 2**

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Question 3
According to the passage, what is the one idea that is common to all forms of anarchism?

What is this question REALLY asking? Strip it down: Across all types, what never changes? The core idea.

What can we anticipate before touching the options? The "Invariant core" established in Paragraph 4: The state is the enemy. Rejection of central authority.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option 1:** *There is no idea common to all forms of anarchism; that is why it is anarchic.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Paragraph 4 explicitly gives a shared belief. *Don't overthink it.*
  - ❌ **Kill: Contradicted by passage**
- **Option 2:** *They all focus on the primacy of the power of the individual.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Not everyone. Anarchist-communism focuses on community control.
  - ❌ **Kill: Overgeneralisation**
- **Option 3:** *They all derive from the work of Pierre-Joseph Proudhon.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** He adopted the word and started it, but "all derive" is a false universality not claimed by the author.
  - ❌ **Kill: False universality**
- **Option 4:** *They are all opposed to the centralisation of power in the state.*
  - **Evaluation: Keep.** State is the enemy. This is the definition of the whole group.
  - ✅ **Keep: Invariant core**

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 4**

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Question 4
The author states that the new ruling class of politicians betrayed the principles of the French Revolution but does not specify in what way. In the context of the passage, which statement below is the likeliest explanation of that betrayal?

What is this question REALLY asking? This is a guided inference. The question is forcing the audience to think: If the betrayal was re-establishing centralized power, what were they *expected* to do?

What can we anticipate before touching the options? People expected the revolution to free them. Instead, the new rulers used the workers' anger to ride to power and then turned to oppress them.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option 1:** *The new ruling class rode to power on the strength of the workers' revolutionary anger, but then turned to oppress that very class.*
  - **Evaluation: Keep.** Matches Paragraph 3 perfectly: uprising won by ordinary population, then betrayed by politicians re-establishing state power and using violence.
  - ✅ **Keep**
- **Option 2:** *The anarchists did not want a new ruling class, but were not politically strong enough to stop them.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Did you feel the author saying anarchists were "not strong people"? No. This is authorial opinion inserted. Absolute **Alien** logic.
  - ❌ **Kill: Authorial opinion inserted**
- **Option 3:** *The new ruling class was constituted mainly of anarchists who were against the destructive impact of the Revolution on the market.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Stupid. The rulers re-established the state; anarchists hate the state.
  - ❌ **Kill: Logical nonsense**
- **Option 4:** *The new ruling class struck a deal with the old ruling class to share power between them.*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Absolute **Alien** stuff. Did you remember reading any of it?
  - ❌ **Kill: Alien narrative**

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 1**

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Question 5
Of the following sets of concepts, identify the set that is conceptually closest to the concerns of the passage.

What is this question REALLY asking? Ignore events, examples, and names. Look for the structural building blocks.

What can we anticipate before touching the options? We saw: Anarchism, State (enemy), Individual, Freedom, Communism, Mutualism.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option 1:** *Anarchism, Betrayal, Power, State*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** "Betrayal" appears in Paragraphs 2 and 3 as the origin story. It is a temporal event. It doesn't define the philosophy itself.
  - ❌ **Kill: Temporal idea**
- **Option 2:** *Revolution, State, Strike, Egoism*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** Strike" is absolute **Alien** noise—never discussed. "Egoism" is a minor mention in Para 6 (Max Stirner). These don't represent the passage.
  - ❌ **Kill: Noise**
- **Option 3:** *Revolution, State, Protection, Liberals*
  - **Evaluation: Kill.** "Protection" is not a central concern. "Liberals" are mentioned once in a comparison in the final paragraph. They are incidental.
  - ❌ **Kill: Side mentions**
- **Option 4:** *Anarchism, State, Individual, Freedom*
  - **Evaluation: Keep.** This set is perfect. Anarchism (Definition/Para 1), State (Core belief/Para 4), Individual (Classification 2/Para 6), and Freedom (Classification 1/Para 5). These four concepts carry the weight of the entire structure.
  - ✅ **Keep**

✅ **Correct Answer: Option 4**

Final Takeaway
Force yourself to pick **only ONE idea**. Not two. Not a balanced summary. Not a "this-and-that".
One idea.

It will feel uncomfortable, especially in expository passages.
That discomfort is normal.

Leave everything else behind: names, examples, sub-types, historical colour.

Whatever idea you pick is **your idea**. Stick with it and move on.

You are **not expected to remember everything**.
You are expected to know **where to go back** if a question demands detail.

Pick one idea per paragraph.
Keep moving.
That is enough.

LESSON HANDOUT

Lesson 5.1: Doodling Analytical Passage

Doodling an Analytical CAT Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 2

Before You Start Reading (Read This First)

This lesson has one non-negotiable rule. For every paragraph, you will pick **ONLY ONE** analytical idea.
Not two. Not a "balanced" summary. Not a long sentence that sounds intelligent. **One idea.**

At this point, many students panic.

- *"What if I don't understand the words?"*
- *"What if I don't know what lifeworlds or epistemology means?"*
- *"What if I am reading this for the first time in my life?"*

That is normal. Now read this carefully: Analytical passages are **NOT** testing your subject knowledge. They are testing whether you can follow how the author is thinking.

So stop trying to understand everything. Start trying to understand why each paragraph exists. **Leave these behind while reading:**

- difficult terminology
- philosophical labels
- proper nouns
- examples
- your desire to feel confident

If a question later demands detail, you will return. Until then, your job is **control, not mastery.**

Expository vs Analytical (Quick Reset)

Expository passages answer: **What is X?** Analytical passages answer: **So what about X?**
They examine:

- how X works
- how X should be studied
- what X does to the world

In this passage, the author is not quietly explaining. The author is telling us how visual culture must be analysed. **This is an analytical passage.**

LESSON HANDOUT

Demonstration Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 2

- **Source:** *The Sacred Gaze* – David Morgan
- **Stats:** 488 words | 21 sentences | ~23 words per sentence | 6 paragraphs | ~16 Flesch Kincaid Grade Level

Look, long sentences are not the problem. **Lack of control is.**

The Passage and the Doodles

Paragraph 1

Text

The claims advanced here may be condensed into two assertions: first, that visual culture is what images, acts of seeing, and attendant intellectual, emotional, and perceptual sensibilities do to build, maintain, or transform the worlds in which people live. And second, that the study of visual culture is the analysis and interpretation of images and the ways of seeing (or gazes) that configure the agents, practices, conceptualities, and institutions that put images to work.

Explanation

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The Passage and the Doodles

Paragraph 1

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The claims advanced here may be condensed into two assertions: first, that visual culture is what images, acts of seeing, and attendant intellectual, emotional, and perceptual sensibilities do to build, maintain, or transform the worlds in which people live. And second, that the study of visual culture is the analysis and interpretation of images and the ways of seeing (or gazes) that configure the agents, practices, conceptualities, and institutions that put images to work.

Explanation

The opening phrase is doing heavy work. "The claims advanced here" tells you the author is asserting, not reporting facts or summarising others' views.

Now slow down. This paragraph looks dense, but ask one simple control question: **If everything else is removed, what must remain for the paragraph to still make sense?**

Start removing. Remove the long list of "intellectual, emotional, perceptual sensibilities" and the list of "agents, practices, institutions" and the academic rhythm. The paragraph still survives.

Now remove this idea: **Visual culture builds, maintains, or transforms the worlds people live in.** The paragraph collapses.

So what is this paragraph really doing? It is laying down two foundations:

1. Visual culture shapes reality.
2. Studying visual culture means analysing images and ways of seeing.

This paragraph is not giving detail. It is setting the analytical frame for everything that follows. **Do not summarise. Do not rewrite. Just lock the role.**

Doodle Visual culture = shapes reality + must be analysed

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Paragraph 2

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Paragraph 2

Text

Accordingly, the study of visual culture should be characterized by several concerns. First, scholars of visual culture need to examine any and all imagery—high and low, art and nonart. They must not restrict themselves to objects of a particular beauty or aesthetic value. Indeed, any kind of imagery may be found to offer up evidence of the visual construction of reality.

Explanation

The word "Accordingly" is a signal. It means: given what we just established, this follows. The author is now explaining how analysis should begin.

Students often get distracted by: high vs low, art vs non-art, or the examples. **Ignore all of that.** Ask again: What breaks if this idea is removed?

If you remove "beauty", "aesthetic value", or the examples, nothing breaks. If you remove this idea: **Scholars must examine any and all imagery**, the paragraph collapses. So this paragraph is about **scope**, not categories.

Doodle Analyse ALL imagery

Paragraph 3

Text

Second, the study of visual culture must scrutinize visual practice as much as images themselves, asking what images do when they are put to use. If scholars engaged in this enterprise inquire what makes an image beautiful or why this image or that constitutes a masterpiece or a work of genius, they should do so with the purpose of investigating an artist's or a work's contribution to the experience of beauty, taste, value, or genius. No amount of social analysis can account fully for the existence of Michelangelo or Leonardo. They were unique creators of images that changed the way their contemporaries thought and felt and have continued to shape the history of art, artists, museums, feeling, and aesthetic value. But study of the critical, artistic, and popular reception of works by such artists can shed important light on the meaning of these artists and their works for many different people. And the history of meaning-making has a great deal to do with how scholars as well as lay audiences today understand these artists and their achievements.

Explanation

This paragraph scares students because it is long. **Length is the trap.** Ask the control question again: Why does this paragraph exist?

It does **not** exist to teach you about Michelangelo, Leonardo, art history, or genius. Those are concessions. The real move happens in the first sentence: **Analyse what images do, not just what they are.**

If you remove the names, the praise, and the examples, the paragraph still stands. If you remove: **focus on visual practice and effects**, the paragraph collapses.

Doodle Analyse visual practice (what images do)

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Doodling Analytical Passage

Doodle Analyse visual practice (what images do)

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Paragraph 4
Text
Third, scholars studying visual culture might properly focus their interpretative work on lifeworlds by examining images, practices, visual technologies, taste, and artistic style as constitutive of social relations. The task is to understand how artifacts contribute to the construction of a world. Important methodological implications follow: ethnography and reception studies become productive forms of gathering information, since these move beyond the image as a closed and fixed meaning-event.

Explanation
Many students freeze at the word "lifeworlds".
Do not. Ask the same question: What breaks if this idea is removed?

If you remove "ethnography", or "reception studies", nothing breaks.
If you remove this idea: **Meaning is not fixed and emerges from social relations**, the paragraph collapses. This paragraph reframes images as social, not static.

Doodle Analyse images as social relations

Paragraph 5
Text
Fourth, scholars may learn a great deal when they scrutinize the constituents of vision, that is, the structures of perception as a physiological process as well as the epistemological frameworks informing a system of visual representation. Vision is a socially and a biologically constructed operation, depending on the design of the human body and how it engages the interpretive devices developed by a culture in order to see intelligibly. Seeing operates on the foundation of covenants with images that establish the conditions for meaningful visual experience.

Explanation
This paragraph shifts focus again. It is no longer about images. It is about **seeing itself. Ignore:** epistemology and philosophy.

Track the move. The author is saying:
1. Vision is not neutral.
2. It is shaped by biology and culture.

That is enough.

Doodle Analyse perception (seeing is socially constructed)

Paragraph 6
Text
Finally, the scholar of visual culture seeks to regard images as evidence for explanation, not as epiphenomena.

Explanation
Short paragraph. Heavy payoff. This is the destination. Images are not side-effects. They are **evidence.**

Doodle Image = evidence

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Doodling Analytical Passage

Short paragraph. Heavy payoff. This is the destination. Images are not side-effects. They are **evidence.**

Doodle Image = evidence

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Passage Structure (The Doodles)

- Visual culture shapes reality
- → Analyse ALL imagery
- → Analyse visual practice
- → Analyse social relations
- → Analyse perception
- → Image as evidence

This structure is enough.

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QUESTIONS AND OPTION-BY-OPTION EXPLANATIONS

Question 1
Which set of keywords below most closely captures the arguments of the passage?

What is this question REALLY asking?
This question is **NOT** asking for examples, names, or impressive words. It is asking: **Which option best reflects the analytical structure of the passage?**

What can we anticipate before touching the options? We need a set that maps to the five pillars we just doodled: Imagery, Practices, Social Relations, Perception, and Evidence.

Option-by-Option Evaluation

- **Option 1:** *Visual Culture, Aesthetic Value, Lay Audience, Visual Experience*
  - **Evaluation:** This option gives weight to aesthetic value. But Paragraph 2 explicitly says **not** to restrict analysis to beauty or aesthetics. This directly contradicts the passage.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 2:** *Scholars, Social Analysis, Michelangelo and Leonardo, Interpretive Devices*
  - **Evaluation:** Michelangelo and Leonardo appear only as concessions, not as core arguments. Names are never the backbone of a passage.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 3:** *Imagery, Visual Practices, Lifeworlds, Structures of Perception*
  - **Evaluation:** Each term maps cleanly onto the paragraph-level ideas: imagery (Para 2), visual practice (Para 3), social relations/lifeworlds (Para 4), perception (Para 5).
  - ✅ **Correct.**
- **Option 4:** *Visual Construction of Reality, Work of Genius, Ethnography, Epiphenomena*
  - **Evaluation:** "Work of genius" is explicitly downplayed in Paragraph 3.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**

Correct Answer: Option 3

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Question 2
All of the following statements may be considered valid inferences from the passage, EXCEPT:

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Question 2
All of the following statements may be considered valid inferences from the passage, EXCEPT:

What is this question REALLY testing?
This is a presence–absence test. Three statements must logically follow from the passage. One introduces an idea the author never commits to.

What can we anticipate before touching the options? The "Except" will likely be a statement that adds a restrictive condition (like "requires X") that the author hasn't mentioned.

Option-by-Option Evaluation

- **Option 1:** *Artifacts are meaningful because they help construct the meanings of the world for us.*
  - **Evaluation:** This is supported by Paragraphs 1 and 4.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 2:** *Studying visual culture requires institutional structures without which the structures of perception cannot be analysed.*
  - **Evaluation:** This introduces a **necessary condition** the author never states. Nothing in the passage says analysis is impossible without institutions.
  - ✅ **Keep.**
- **Option 3:** *Understanding the structures of perception is an important part of understanding how visual cultures work.*
  - **Evaluation:** Paragraph 5 supports this.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 4:** *Visual culture is not just about how we see, but also about how visual practices can impact and change the world.*
  - **Evaluation:** Paragraphs 1 and 3 support this.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**

Correct Answer: Option 2

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Question 3
"No amount of social analysis can account fully for the existence of Michelangelo or Leonardo." What does this mean?

What is this question REALLY asking? This is a paraphrase with restraint question. Avoid exaggeration. Avoid extremes.

What can we anticipate before touching the options? The author is admitting there is a limit to social analysis when it comes to "genius," but he isn't saying we shouldn't analyse them at all.

Option-by-Option Evaluation

- **Option 1:** *Social analytical accounts of people like Michelangelo or Leonardo cannot explain their genius.*
  - **Evaluation:** This captures the concession the author makes.
  - ✅ **Correct.**
- **Option 2:** *Michelangelo or Leonardo cannot be subjected to social analysis because of their genius.*
  - **Evaluation: Rotten.** The passage does **NOT** say analysis is impossible.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 3:** *No analyses exist of Michelangelo's or Leonardo's social accounts.*
  - **Evaluation:** 100% false statement.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 4:** *Socially existing beings cannot be analysed.*
  - **Evaluation:** Word salad. **100% false.**
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**

Correct Answer: Option 1

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Question 4
Meaning of "Seeing operates on the foundation of covenants with images..."

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Question 4
Meaning of "Seeing operates on the foundation of covenants with images..."

What is this question REALLY asking? It is asking you to preserve the **cause → condition → meaning** relationship.

 What can we anticipate before touching the options? Covenants (agreements) are the foundation that allows seeing to be meaningful.

Option-by-Option Evaluation

- **Option 1:** *Sight becomes a meaningful visual experience because shared interpretive agreements shape how we see images.*
  - **Evaluation:** This preserves the causal logic.
  - ✅ **Correct.**
- **Option 2:** *The way we experience sight is through images operated on by meaningful covenants.*
  - **Evaluation:** This reverses the direction of influence.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 3:** *Images are meaningful visual experiences when they have a foundation of covenants seeing them.*
  - **Evaluation:** Illogical structure.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 4:** *Sight becomes meaningful when images of covenants establish foundational conditions.*
  - **Evaluation:** Word salad.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**

Correct Answer: Option 1

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Question 5
Which one of the following best describes the word "epiphenomena" in the last sentence of the passage?

What is this question REALLY asking?
The author defines the word by contrast. **Evidence** = central and explanatory. **Epiphenomena** = not central, not explanatory.

What can we anticipate before touching the options? We are looking for a word that means "side-effect" or "non-essential."

Option-by-Option Evaluation

- **Option 1:** *Phenomena amenable to analysis.*
  - **Evaluation:** This describes something important and analysable. That is the opposite of what the author means.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 2:** *Phenomena supplemental to the evidence.*
  - **Evaluation:** "Supplemental" means secondary and non-essential. This matches the author's contrast exactly.
  - ✅ **Correct.**
- **Option 3:** *Overarching collections of images.*
  - **Evaluation:** This talks about size, not explanatory status.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**
- **Option 4:** *Visual phenomena of epic proportions.*
  - **Evaluation:** Sound-based trap.
  - ❌ **Eliminate.**

Correct Answer: Option 2

Final Takeaway
Pick one idea per paragraph. Ignore what you don't understand. Track what the author is **DOING**.
I's almost mechanical.

LESSON HANDOUT

Lesson 6.1: Doodling Argumentative Passage

Doodling an Analytical CAT Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 2

Before You Start Reading (Read This First)

We need to fix a massive misunderstanding before we even touch the text. Most students think an "argument" is a shouting match or a debate between two people. An argument does **NOT** need two people. It only needs two components:

1. **Claim / Conclusion**
   → what the author wants you to believe
2. **Reasons / Evidence**
   → why the author wants you to believe it

That's it.

Premise(s) + Conclusion = Argument

Everything else in the passage is decoration.

Why Argumentative Passages Are Different (and Fun)

In an argumentative passage, the author is personally involved. They have a dog in the fight. This changes the game because *The Question Setter* can now ask:

- What is the author's conclusion?
- What does the author agree with?
- What supports or weakens the argument?
- What is the author's underlying assumption?

You can't ask these in neutral expository passages. But in argumentative ones, once you spot the author's position, everything else becomes manageable.

Expository vs Analytical vs Argumentative (Final Reset)

Lock this hierarchy into your brain:

- **Expository:** Explains *what* X is (Author is invisible).
- **Analytical:** Examines *how* X works (Author is a guide).
- **Argumentative:** Argues what should be *believed/done/rejected* (Author is loud and clear).

In an argumentative passage, only **ONE** thing matters: **the author's position.**

LESSON HANDOUT

Demonstration Passage: CAT 2020 Slot 3

Source: *Whoops!: Why Everyone Owes Everyone and No One Can Pay* – John Lanchester

Stats:

- ~495 words
- 16 sentences
- ~31 words per sentence
- **2 paragraphs**

Look, one paragraph here is almost 400 words. That is a deliberate trap to make you panic and pick multiple ideas. **You will not.** You will still pick one idea per paragraph.

What You Are Looking for While Reading

Before you read a single line, tell yourself:

- I am not here to understand economics
- I am not here to understand finance
- I am not here to remember facts

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What You Are Looking for While Reading
Before you read a single line, tell yourself:

- I am not here to understand economics
- I am not here to understand finance
- I am not here to remember facts

I am here to answer **one question only**:
What does the author want me to believe?
Everything else serves that purpose.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 1
Text
I've been following the economic crisis for more than two years now. I began working on the subject as part of the

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LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 1

Text

I've been following the economic crisis for more than two years now. I began working on the subject as part of the background to a novel, and soon realized that I had stumbled across the most interesting story I've ever found. While I was beginning to work on it, the British bank Northern Rock blew up, and it became clear that, as I wrote at the time, "If our laws are not extended to control the new kinds of super-powerful, super-complex, and potentially super-risky investment vehicles, they will one day cause a financial disaster of global-systemic proportions." . . . I was both right and too late, because all the groundwork for the crisis had already been done—though the sluggishness of the world's governments, in not preparing for the great unraveling of autumn 2008, was then and still is stupefying. But this is the first reason why I wrote this book: because what's happened is extraordinarily interesting. It is an absolutely amazing story, full of human interest and drama, one whose byways of mathematics, economics, and psychology are both central to the story of the last decades and mysteriously unknown to the general public. We have heard a lot about "the two cultures" of science and the arts—we heard a particularly large amount about it in 2009, because it was the fiftieth anniversary of the speech during which C. P. Snow first used the phrase. But I'm not sure the idea of a huge gap between science and the arts is as true as it was half a century ago—it's certainly true, for instance, that a general reader who wants to pick up an education in the fundamentals of science will find it easier than ever before. It seems to me that there is a much bigger gap between the world of finance and that of the general public and that there is a need to narrow that gap, if the financial industry is not to be a kind of priesthood, administering to its own mysteries and feared and resented by the rest of us. Many bright, literate people have no idea about all sorts of economic basics, of a type that financial insiders take as elementary facts of how the world works. I am an outsider to finance and economics, and my hope is that I can talk across that gulf.

Explanation

This paragraph is long, but its job is singular. Start with the control question: **Why does this paragraph exist?**

Many students get distracted by:

- the author's personal story (novel, background)
- the specific bank collapse (Northern Rock)
- the prediction about laws and super-risky investment vehicles
- references to science, arts, mathematics, economics, and psychology
- the "two cultures" of C. P. Snow

All of this is **support**, not the idea. Apply the collapse test. Remove the novel, the prediction, the bank example, the interdisciplinary references, and the "two cultures" discussion. The paragraph still makes sense.

Now remove this idea: **There is a much bigger gap between the world of finance and that of the general public and that there is a need to narrow that gap.** The paragraph collapses completely.

So what is the author really doing? He is establishing credibility and making a clear claim. The claim is not about the 2008 crisis itself; it is about **distance**. Finance has become an opaque "priesthood," ordinary people are excluded and fear it, and this gap must be narrowed so the author (an outsider) can "talk across that gulf."

Doodle Finance–public gap exists → must be narrowed

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LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 2

Text

LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 2
Text
My need to understand is the same as yours, whoever you are. That's one of the strangest ironies of this story: after decades in which the ideology of the Western world was personally and economically individualistic, we've suddenly been hit by a crisis which shows in the starkest terms that whether we like it or not—and there are large parts of it that you would have to be crazy to like—we're all in this together. The aftermath of the crisis is going to dominate the economics and politics of our societies for at least a decade to come and perhaps longer.

Explanation
This paragraph is short, but it carries the final position. Ask the control question again: **What would break if this paragraph did not exist?** Without this paragraph, Paragraph 1 would only describe a problem (the gap), but there would be no clear normative stance on what the crisis *taught* us.

Strip the paragraph. Remove the emotional phrasing ("whoever you are"), the irony, and the aside about "you would have to be crazy to like it."

Now remove this idea: **The ideology of individualism is inadequate; the crisis shows that we're all in this together (collective reality).** The paragraph collapses.

So what is the author doing here? He is drawing the final conclusion of the argument. Paragraph 1 says: there is a dangerous gap between finance and the public that must be narrowed. Paragraph 2 completes the logic by saying: the old belief in individualism does not hold; the crisis proves that we are all collectively affected. Therefore, collective understanding and responsibility are unavoidable. This is the author's position.

Doodle Individualism fails → collective responsibility is necessary

---

Passage Structure (The Doodles)
Now combine the two paragraph doodles.

- Finance–public gap exists → must be narrowed
- Individualism fails → collective responsibility is necessary

---

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LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTIONS AND OPTION-BY-OPTION EXPLANATIONS

LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTIONS AND OPTION-BY-OPTION EXPLANATIONS

Question 1
Which one of the following best captures the main argument of the last paragraph of the passage?

What is this question REALLY asking?
This is a conclusion-identification question. It is NOT asking what phrase sounds dramatic or what word is repeated. It is asking: What belief does the author want you to accept after reading the last paragraph? So go back to the doodle of Paragraph 2.

What can we anticipate before touching the options?
We are looking for the idea that individualism is a failed lens and we are actually in a collective reality that requires us to move past that old ideology.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option A:** *Whoever you are, you would be crazy to think that there is no crisis.*
  - **Evaluation:** This picks up the word "crazy" and turns it into the conclusion. The author is not arguing about sanity. That word is only emotional emphasis. **Rotten.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option B:** *In the decades to come, other ideologies will emerge in the aftermath of the crisis.*
  - **Evaluation:** The author never predicts "new" ideologies emerging. He talks about consequences, not ideological evolution. **Alien.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option C:** *The ideology of individualism must be set aside in order to deal with the crisis.*
  - **Evaluation:** This directly matches the doodle: individualism fails, collective reality matters.
  - ✅ **Keep.**
- **Option D:** *The aftermath of the crisis will strengthen the central ideology of individualism in the Western world.*
  - **Evaluation:** This is the exact opposite of what the author argues. **Lies.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**

Correct Answer: Option C

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 2
According to the passage, the author is likely to be supportive of which one of the following programmes?

What is this question REALLY asking?
This is an author-agreement question. Ask yourself: If the author were designing a programme, what would it try to do? Go back to Paragraph 1 doodle.

What can we anticipate before touching the options?
The author wants to bridge the gap. He wants the "general public" to understand what the "insiders" already know so it's not a "priesthood" anymore.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option A:** *An educational curriculum that promotes economic research.*
  - **Evaluation:** Research is for experts. The author is worried about the **general public. Alien.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option B:** *An educational curriculum that promotes developing financial literacy in the masses.*
  - **Evaluation:** This directly addresses the finance–public gap, the lack of basic understanding, and the need to "talk across the gulf."
  - ✅ **Keep.**
- **Option C:** *The complete nationalisation of all financial institutions.*
  - **Evaluation:** The author never argues for state ownership or policy overhaul. **Alien.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option D:** *Economic policies that are more sensitively calibrated to market fluctuations.*
  - **Evaluation:** This is about policy design, not public understanding. **Rotten.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**

Correct Answer: Option B

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 3
Which one of the following, if true, would be an accurate inference from the first sentence of the passage?

What is this question REALLY asking?
This is a pure inference question. No ideology. No argument. Only logic. Take the first sentence alone: "I've been following the economic crisis for more than two years now."

What can we anticipate before touching the options?
If something has lasted more than two years $x > 2$, it is definitely not less than two years.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option A:** *The author's preoccupation with the economic crisis is not less than two years old.*
  - **Evaluation:** If something has lasted "more than two years," it is definitely "not less than two years." This is a safe, logical inference.
  - ✅ **Keep.**
- **Option B:** *The economic crisis outlasted the author's preoccupation with it.*
  - **Evaluation:** No such comparison is made. **Alien.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option C:** *The author is preoccupied with the economic crisis because he is being followed.*
  - **Evaluation: Rotten.** Wordplay trap on "following."
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option D:** *The author has witnessed many economic crises by travelling a lot for two years.*
  - **Evaluation:** Nothing about travel or multiple crises. **Alien.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**

Correct Answer: Option A

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Question 4
All of the following, if true, could be seen as supporting the arguments in the passage, EXCEPT:

What is this question REALLY testing?
This is a support vs contradiction test. Three statements must align with the author. One must undermine the author's logic.

Option Evaluation:

- **Option A:** *The story of the economic crisis also involves international relations, global financial security, and mass psychology.*
  - **Evaluation:** This strengthens the idea that finance is complex, interdisciplinary, and opaque. Supports the author.
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option B:** *Economic crises could be averted by changing prevailing ideologies and beliefs.*
  - **Evaluation:** The author explicitly attacks the ideology of individualism. This aligns with his stance. Supports him.
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option C:** *The failure of economic systems does not necessarily mean the failure of their ideologies.*
  - **Evaluation:** This defends the existing ideologies (like individualism) even when the system fails. That directly contradicts the author's conclusion in Para 2.
  - ✅ **Keep.**
- **Option D:** *Financial matters have become so arcane that they are hard for people to understand.*
  - **Evaluation:** This supports the finance–public gap argument in Para 1. Supports him.
  - ❌ **Kill.**

Correct Answer: Option C

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LESSON HANDOUT

Question 5
Which one of the following, if false, could be seen as supporting the author's claims?

What is this question REALLY asking?

Fix the question first:
If false, supporting → If true, NOT supporting.

So we are really asking: Which option, if true, does NOT support the author's argument?

What can we anticipate before touching the options?
We are looking for an option that, if taken as a true fact, would undermine his claim that finance is a "priesthood" or that the crisis was a "failure of individualism."

Option Evaluation:

- **Option 1:** *"The global economic crisis lasted for more than two years."*
  - **Evaluation:** If true, this directly supports the very first sentence of the passage and his authority on the topic. **Supports.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option 2:** *"The huge gap between science and the arts has steadily narrowed over time."*
  - **Evaluation:** The author explicitly says the science–arts gap is not the real issue anymore. Even if true, it does not hurt his argument about the finance gap. **Supports.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**
- **Option 3:** *"The economic crisis was not a failure of collective action to rectify economic problems."*
  - **Evaluation:** Read it slowly, as true. If this is true, it means collective action did **NOT** fail. But the author's core claim is that individualism failed and we missed our collective responsibility ("we are all in this together"). This option, if true, directly undermines the author's argument.
  - ✅ **Keep.**
- **Option 4:** *"Most people are yet to gain any real understanding of the workings of the financial world."*
  - **Evaluation:** This directly supports the "gap" argument and the author's whole reason for writing. **Supports.**
  - ❌ **Kill.**

✅ **Final Answer: Option 3**

Final Takeaway (Argumentative Passage)
In an argumentative passage, everything revolves around the author's position. Your job is not to understand the topic in detail. Your job is to answer one question: **What does the author want me to believe?**

Once you lock that position:

- Every paragraph becomes either setting up the problem or pushing the conclusion.
- Stories, examples, and background are support, not ideas.
- Questions become predictable: author agreement, support/weaken, inference, assumption.

One paragraph = one argumentative role.
If your doodle is right, the questions are mechanical.

And when CAT plays games with wording like "if false, supporting," don't panic.
Fix the question first. Then solve it normally.

That's it.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Killing the Options

Lesson 1.1: Think like the Question Setter

This lesson is not about RC accuracy. It's not about science, and it's definitely not about philosophy. This lesson is about how CAT questions are **born**.

Why this lesson exists

To help you understand the mindset of the Question Setter

They start with:

- the **idea**
- the **utility of that idea**
- the **traps that idea allows**

And only then do they write questions.

This lesson shows you **that process live**.

LESSON HANDOUT

Step 1: Choosing the passage (setter thinking)

The original essay was ~3,800 words. (https://aeon.co/essays/science-needs-disagreement-what-makes-some-disagreement-useless)

I asked myself:

- Can this idea survive trimming?
- Does it have a **general principle**, not just a specific case?
- Does it allow for a Main Idea + Inference + EXCEPT question?
- Can the examples (vaccines, climate change) be misused as traps?

That's how the passage came down to ~528 words. What survived was not "good writing." What survived was **question-worthiness**.

The Passage (edited, as used in class)

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The Passage (edited, as used in class)

Those who worry about a 'war on science' frequently point to badly behaving individuals or groups who contradict a scientific consensus for some nefarious or irrational purpose such as pseudoscientific critics of climate change, natural selection and vaccines. If a scientific community's power to nurture valuable misunderstandings is a yardstick of its vibrancy, then these science deniers are problematic because they perpetuate misunderstandings that are no longer valuable. This typically occurs when there have been extensive and adequate corrective responses to misunderstandings. In other words, if scientists have already expanded their theoretical, methodological and empirical apparatuses to correct a misunderstanding – and, in the process, have already taken that misunderstanding as a serious possibility – then holding fast to that misunderstanding is pernicious.

To appreciate this point, consider the scientific community's response to vaccine scepticism. The fountainhead of misinformation is a (now-retracted) paper purporting to establish a vaccine-autism link. Long before this study, scientists responded to concerns about vaccines' safety by testing several hypotheses relating to their interactions with the immune system. Thus, some of the public's misunderstanding of vaccines had already begun to be transformed into understanding even before the publication of this study. Immediately following the paper's publication in 1998, numerous studies were conducted that tested various hypotheses that either linked vaccines and autism or claimed that too many vaccines could 'overwhelm' the immune system. These studies resulted in the rejection of these hypotheses and the generation of several alternative hypotheses that could be subject to future testing. As a result, the scientific community's corrections of these misunderstandings have advanced scientific understanding. In short, for a time, the hypothesis that vaccines cause autism was a valuable misunderstanding. Given that much of this work was done because of public concerns about vaccine safety, this example nicely illustrates how corrective processes can be effectively employed regardless of whether the misunderstanding comes from inside or outside the scientific community.

Science deniers, however, undermine the integrity of science when they fail to recognise the expiration date on valuable misunderstandings. Once the hard work of generating alternative hypotheses, collecting data and testing various ideas has been done, we might ask whether repeatedly responding to the same dissent or misunderstanding is valuable. This is an especially pressing question given the recent resurgence in vaccine scepticism and suggestions by Robert F Kennedy Jr that additional testing on the safety of vaccines is necessary. While initial responses to the public misunderstanding of vaccines have borne many scientific advances, much of the value of responding to those original lines of dissent has been exhausted and further testing is unlikely to produce new understanding.

So, on our view, the chief sin of science deniers is clinging to a misunderstanding that is no longer valuable. Valuable misunderstandings remind us to avoid fetishising consensus and to recall that effectively responding to dissent and criticism is a longstanding staple of scientific practice. Indeed, communities brimming with valuable misunderstandings but bereft of consensus develop several lines of research that critically engage each other. By contrast, a consensus that abhors valuable misunderstandings can be the result of groupthink, laziness or resistance to alternative viewpoints.

LESSON HANDOUT

How I actually thought while creating the questions

This is the part of the game that students usually never see.

Before I even thought of the first question, I did one non-negotiable thing: **I forced myself to behave like a test-taker.** I reminded myself of one brutal truth: I can sit and analyse this passage for an hour, but you—the CAT aspirant—cannot. You have minutes.

So the first question I asked wasn't *"What can I ask?"* It was: **"What are the key ideas that a good reader should catch in one reading?"** If an idea is too buried to be caught in one careful read, it has no business being rewarded in a CAT question.

Step 1: Fix the key idea of each paragraph

misunderstandings remind us to avoid fetishising consensus and to recall that effectively responding to dissent and criticism is a longstanding staple of scientific practice. Indeed, communities brimming with valuable misunderstandings but bereft of consensus develop several lines of research that critically engage each other. By contrast, a consensus that abhors valuable misunderstandings can be the result of groupthink, laziness or resistance to alternative viewpoints.

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So the first question I asked wasn't *"What can I ask?"* It was: **"What are the key ideas that a good reader should catch in one reading?"** If an idea is too buried to be caught in one careful read, it has no business being rewarded in a CAT question.

Step 1: Fix the key idea of each paragraph

Before questions. Before options. I first froze the **key idea of each paragraph.**
Not details. Not examples. Not names.
Only what a **strong reader** should carry forward after one reading.
Here is how the passage breaks down.

Paragraph 1 – Key Idea

The author reframes the problem:
disagreement and misunderstanding are not automatically harmful to science, but become problematic **when they persist after adequate correction.**
This paragraph introduces:

- the idea of **"valuable misunderstanding"**
- and quietly plants the idea of **expiry**

This is **conceptual framing**, not the example yet.

Paragraph 2 – Key Idea

The vaccine scepticism example shows **how misunderstanding can be productive** when it:

- triggers investigation
- leads to correction
- advances scientific understanding

This paragraph answers:
How can misunderstanding actually help science?
Vaccines are **only the illustration**, not the argument.

Paragraph 3 – Key Idea

Misunderstandings **lose value once they have been thoroughly addressed**, and continuing to respond to them **no longer produces new understanding.**
This paragraph introduces:

- the **expiration date**
- diminishing returns
- why repetition becomes wasteful

This is the **hinge** of the passage.

Paragraph 4 – Key Idea

The real problem with science deniers is **clinging to expired misunderstandings**, not disagreement itself; and **valuable misunderstandings are essential to avoid groupthink**, while rejecting them too early leads to

Misunderstandings **lose value once they have been thoroughly addressed**, and continuing to respond to them **no longer produces new understanding**.

This paragraph introduces:

- the **expiration date**
- diminishing returns
- why repetition becomes wasteful

This is the **hinge** of the passage.

LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph 4 – Key Idea

The real problem with science deniers is **clinging to expired misunderstandings**, not disagreement itself; and **valuable misunderstandings are essential to avoid groupthink**, while rejecting them too early leads to stagnation.

This paragraph:

- delivers the **judgement**
- broadens the implication beyond vaccines
- contrasts healthy dissent with dead consensus

The Passage-Level Spine (what survives all four paragraphs)

Once I had these four ideas in place, one thing became obvious.

Across all four paragraphs, **one idea survives**:

Misunderstandings can be valuable in science, but only as long as they continue to generate new understanding.

Everything else in the passage:

- illustrates this
- limits this
- warns against misusing this
- or applies it more broadly

This is the idea a **good reader** should walk away with after one reading.

And that is the reader I wanted to **reward**.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Creating the Question Stem + Correct Answer + Traps

I did not start by writing four options and then "checking which is best." That's not setter work. That's candidate

LESSON HANDOUT

Creating the Question Stem + Correct Answer + Traps

I did not start by writing four options and then "checking which is best." That's not setter work. That's candidate work. Setter work is clean, clinical, and slightly evil.

Here is the exact order I used:

1. **Frame the question type.**
2. **Write the correct answer first.**
3. **Create three traps.**
4. **Shuffle everything so it looks random.**

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LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTION 1: MAIN IDEA (Global)

Step 1: Create the stem

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LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTION 1: MAIN IDEA (Global)

Step 1: Create the stem

I want a **Global / Main Idea** question. So I write the stem that forces "central thesis", not "topic":

Which of the following best describes the main argument of the author?

That's the stem. Now **I don't touch the wrong options yet.**

Step 2: Create the correct answer FIRST

(Truth Converter Machine)

Now I convert the author's central idea into a CAT-option sentence.

The core spine I want to reward is: misunderstandings can be useful **only up to a point**; after that they stop producing insight.

Truth Converter Machine = same soul, different clothes.

So the correct answer I created is:

✅ **There is a limit where scientific misunderstanding ceases to be useful because it does not lead to new insights.**

This is the **correct option**. Done.

Now, only after this do I create the wrong ones.

Step 3: Create three traps (each with a purpose)

Trap 1: Sidetrack by making the EXAMPLE the HERO

I take the vaccine story and inflate it into "the argument":

❌ *A valuable misunderstanding of vaccine scepticism has led to corrective processes that may be compromised by science-deniers.*

Setter's purpose: to trap the reader who confuses a case study with a **thesis**.

Trap 2: Tone + Lie (make it sound morally correct)

I frame it like a moral complaint about "opposition to science":

❌ *The opposition to scientific inquiry is sustained by individuals who contest scientific consensus for misguided reasons that weaken valuable understandings.*

Setter purpose: trap the reader who hears "war on science" and thinks that's the author's thesis.
Also, trap the reader who misses that the author says misunderstandings can initially be productive.

Trap 3: Direct reversal (attack "valuable misunderstandings")

I flip the passage's valuation:

❌ *Valuable misunderstandings undermine the integrity of scientific consensus and enable science deniers to exploit its vulnerabilities.*

Setter purpose: trap the reader who sees a familiar phrase ("valuable misunderstandings") and assumes it's being criticised, when the author defends it.

Step 4: Shuffle the final 4 options (random order)

Now I don't keep:

- correct = option A
- traps = B/C/D

No.

I shuffle them. The final order becomes whatever. That's why in your test, the correct one is option (3).

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LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTION 2: INFERENCE

Step 1: Create the stem

I want an inference question based on the vaccine example, so I frame the demand:

I shuffle them. The final order becomes whatever. That's why in your test, the correct one is option (3).

LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTION 2: INFERENCE

Step 1: Create the stem

I want an inference question based on the vaccine example, so I frame the demand:

It can be inferred from the example of vaccine scepticism that misunderstanding is most useful when:

Now again: **correct answer first.**

Step 2: Create the correct answer FIRST

(Truth Converter Machine)

The passage says the corrections:

- advanced scientific understanding
- transformed misunderstanding into understanding

So I truth-convert that into a general inference:

✅ **these misunderstandings help enhance knowledge.**

Correct answer done.

Now build traps.

Step 3: Create three traps

Trap 1: Sidetrack into PROCESS instead of OUTPUT

❌ *it prompts the scientific community to rework its hypothesis.*

Setter purpose: trap the reader who stops at "testing happened" instead of "knowledge advanced".

Trap 2: Lie by rewarding REPEATED concerns

❌ *public repeatedly raises similar concerns.*

Setter purpose: trap the reader who hasn't absorbed the "expiry date" idea.

Repeated concerns after expiry are framed as a problem in the passage.

Trap 3: Alien goal: CONSENSUS fetish

❌ *future testing makes scientific consensus possible.*

Setter purpose: trap the "science = consensus" reader.

The author explicitly warns against fetishising consensus.

Step 4: Shuffle final order (random)

Again, options are placed randomly.

Now kill them in that displayed order:

- (1) ✅ Output/knowledge
- (2) Process
- (3) Repetition (contradiction)
- (4) Consensus fetish (contradiction)

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LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTION 3: EXCEPT (Agreement)

Step 1: Create the stem

I want an EXCEPT question because it's a trap format by design:

The author would agree with each of the following EXCEPT that science deniers are problematic because:

Now: as a setter, I lock one killer line first.

Step 2: Lock the killer line (before writing options)

LESSON HANDOUT

QUESTION 3: EXCEPT (Agreement)

Step 1: Create the stem

I want an EXCEPT question because it's a trap format by design:

The author would agree with each of the following EXCEPT that science deniers are problematic because:

Now: as a setter, I lock one killer line first.

Step 2: Lock the killer line (before writing options)

The passage gives me this:

corrective processes can be employed regardless of whether misunderstanding comes from inside or outside the scientific community.

So any option blaming **outsider status** must be the odd one out.

Now I build the correct option (the EXCEPT option) first mentally:

✅ "outsider status" is the lie.

Then I build the others as passage-consistent.

Step 3: Create the three "agree" options

These three must sound safe:

(1) *their misunderstanding offers no utility for the advancement of science.*
(2) *of reasons beyond the fact that they deny scientific consensus.*
(3) *they are unwilling to accept genuine responses from the scientific community.*

All are consistent with:

- utility
- expiry
- refusal to move on
- consensus isn't sacred

Step 4: Create the EXCEPT option (identity trap)

(4) ✅ **they lie beyond the boundaries of the scientific community.**

Setter purpose: bait the sociological stereotype.
Passage kills it explicitly.

Step 5: Shuffle options (random)

Again: displayed order is random.
But the killer line makes (4) die instantly.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Net: why this rewards the good reader

A good reader is rewarded because:

- the correct option is built from the **spine** (truth-converted)
- traps are built from:
  - examples
  - tone
  - reversal
  - identity bias

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  - tone
  - reversal
  - identity bias
  - process fixation
  - consensus fetish

A reader who tracked key ideas in one read will watch traps collapse.
That's the point.

Lesson Takeaway

1. **Key ideas are all the question setter needs to create questions.**
   If you can extract the paragraph-wise key ideas and the one passage-level spine, you already have the raw material for every CAT-style question.

2. **There is always one clear, correct answer.**
   Not "best", not "closest", not "depends". One option matches the spine after truth conversion. That's it.

3. **Every wrong answer is wrong for a reason.**
   Wrong options are not random. Each is built to fail in a specific way: example-trap, scope-trap, tone-trap, reversal, identity bait, process fixation. Once you see the reason, the option dies instantly.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Killing the Options

Lesson 1.2: The Truth & S.T.E.A.L.S.

In the previous lesson, we learnt to think like a Question Setter.
Now we go deeper. Not into passages. Into options.

Because here's the uncomfortable truth: Students don't lose marks in passages. Students lose marks in options.

The passage is your friend. The options are the battlefield. And if you don't understand how truth behaves inside options, you will always hesitate.

LESSON HANDOUT

The Truth Meter

Before touching RC, I started with something deceptively simple.
Statement:
"Jijo has been teaching for the past 25 years."
Now let's see if the following inferences are valid.

Case 1: Implied Truth
"Jijo has more than five years of teaching experience."
This is not verbatim. But it is logically implied. 25 years → more than 5 years. This is **true**.

Case 2: Direct False

There can be other "uncertains"
"Jijo is a great teacher."
The original statement never evaluates quality. It gives duration.
This is **uncertain**, therefore wrong.

"Jijo has significant teaching expertise."

LESSON HANDOUT

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Case 2: Direct False

"Jijo's teaching experience is less than three years."

Contradiction. 25 ≠ less than 3. This is **false**. Easy kill.

Case 3: Uncertain

"Jijo is married."

Can you prove it from the statement?

No.

Is it false? No.

Is it true? No.

It is **indeterminable**.

And here's the key:

In RC, "cannot be determined" = WRONG.

Not because it is false.

But because the passage doesn't give you permission.

There can be other "uncertains"

"Jijo is a great teacher."

The original statement never evaluates quality. It gives duration.

This is **uncertain**, therefore wrong.

"Jijo has significant teaching expertise."

Experience ≠ expertise.

25 years does not automatically imply quality. This is another **uncertain trap**.

What just happened?

Truth in RC can appear in two forms:

1. **Paraphrased Truth**
2. **Implied Truth**

Wrong answers can appear in two forms:

1. **Direct False (Lie)**
2. **Uncertain / Not Given**

Students are comfortable identifying the "lies".

They struggle in identifying:

- implied truths
- uncertain add-ons

That's where marks are lost.

Apply the Truth Meter to a short RC

Now we take the 19th-century passage by Washington Irving

LESSON HANDOUT

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Apply the Truth Meter to a short RC

Now we take the 19th-century passage by Washington Irving

LESSON HANDOUT

I have often had occasion to remark the fortitude with which women sustain the most overwhelming reverses of fortune. Those disasters which break down the spirit of a man, and prostrate him in the dust, seem to call forth all the energies of women, and give such intrepidity and elevation to their character, that at times it approaches to sublimity. Nothing can be more touching, than to behold a woman, who, while threading the prosperous paths of life, had appeared gentle, dependent, and sensitive to life's minor roughnesses, suddenly rising in mental force to be the comforter and support of her husband under misfortune, and abiding with unshrinking firmness the bitterest blasts of adversity.

Passage Core
Women sustain overwhelming reverses, rise in strength during misfortune, and support husbands firmly.

That's the idea.

The Question
Which of the following statements presents the main idea of the paragraph?
Now we enter option forensics.

OPTION FORENSICS
We do NOT read options to find what feels right.
We read options to find **the flaw**.

Option (1)
Women often provide emotional strength to their husbands within marriage.

At first glance — looks correct.
But notice the shift:
Passage context = **misfortune**
Option context = **within marriage**
Marriage is broader. Misfortune is specific. This is a **Scope Expansion**.
Marriage includes:

- routine life
- everyday issues
- neutral situations

The passage speaks only about adversity.
One wrong phrase is enough.
Kill.

LESSON HANDOUT

Option (2)
Men are largely incapable of handling adversity, whereas women consistently display moral and emotional superiority.

Tone problem.
The passage does not demean men. It does not say "incapable". It does not say "superior".

This is a **Tone Mismatch**
Kill.

Option (3)
The weakest of the females can be the source of strength when the occasion calls for it.
Two problems:

- "Weakest of the females" → Extreme
- "Source of strength" → For whom? Broad.

Also, "when the occasion calls for it" is vague.
This is **Extreme + Scope distortion**.
Kill.

Option (4)
Societies should formally recognise and reward women's emotional labour during economic and personal crises.

Where did "society should" come from?
The passage is descriptive, not prescriptive.

This option introduces:

- policy
- reward
- society
- economic crises

This is a classic **Alien Idea**.
Kill.

Option (5)
Biological differences make men inherently more resilient to adversity than women.

Direct contradiction.
Passage says the opposite.
This is a clean **Lie**.
Kill.

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Kill.

LESSON HANDOUT

Option (6)

Women are capable of displaying greater resilience than men during prolonged adversity.

Now this is interesting.

Is it true? Yes.

Does it capture part of the passage? Yes.

 Is it the **main idea**? No.

Because the main idea includes:

- comforting the husband
- support during misfortune
- emotional and moral fortitude

This option narrows the idea to resilience only.

This is a **Sidetrack**.

Kill.

Option (7) ✅

Women often provide support and strength to their spouses in times of misfortune.

Paraphrased truth.

- "Comforter and support" → "support and strength"
- "Husband" → "spouses"
- "Misfortune" preserved

Every word aligns with the passage.

This is the **Truth**.

Correct Answer: (7)

The S.T.E.A.L.S. Framework

Wrong answers are not random. They are engineered. Use this toolkit to dismantle them:

Letter	Trap Type	Logic
S	Scope	Too broad (marriage) or too narrow (just resilience).
T	Tone	Too harsh, too flowery, or judgmental compared to the author.
E	Extreme	Words like *all, none, always, never, weakest, best*.
A	Alien Idea	Concepts never mentioned (society, policy, rewards).
L	Lie	Direct contradiction of the passage facts.
S	Sidetrack	True statement, but misses the core point/main argument.

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STEALS Framework

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Lesson Takeaway

1. Truth can be paraphrased or implied.
2. Wrong answers are either false or uncertain.
3. One wrong word is enough to kill an option.
4. You are not evaluating options.
5. You are scanning for the flaw.

If you can read options like this, you don't get stuck. You kill.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 2.1: The Paraphrased Truth

The Game Plan

In the previous lesson, we learnt to think like the Question Setter. Then we learnt that truth in RC can appear in two forms:

1. **Paraphrased Truth** → *Same soul, different clothes.*
2. **Implied Truth** → *The logic bridge.*

This lesson is about the first of these. Because let's be honest: many students do *not* lose marks because they miss the passage. They lose marks because they look at the actual truth in the options and go, *"No sir, this seems different."*

Different words. Same idea.
And that is exactly where the trouble begins.

LESSON HANDOUT

Where Paraphrased Truth Appears

A question may ask:

- *Which of the following is true according to the passage?*
- *The author would agree with which of the following?*

Here, your job is simple: **find the truth.**
But a question may also ask:

- *Each of the following is true except*
- *Each of the following can be inferred from the passage except*

Now the format changes. Here, three options are truths, and one option is not. So again, unless you know how truth behaves inside options, you are in trouble.
In other words, killing the wrong options is not enough. You must also be able to recognise the "truth" when it appears in disguise.

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LESSON HANDOUT

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In other words, killing the wrong options is not enough. You must also be able to recognise the "truth" when it appears in disguise.

Why Students Get Confused

The truth in the passage and the truth in the option are *not* always written in the same words. That is the whole issue. The passage uses one set of words. The option may use another set of words. But if the idea remains the same, then the option is still **true**.

So stop expecting the correct answer to behave like a photocopy. The Question Setter is not in the business of copy-pasting lines from the passage into the option. They are in the business of **truth conversion**.

Same truth. Different clothes.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Three Ways Truth Gets Paraphrased

You do not need to become technical and start classifying everything in the exam hall. But you should know how paraphrasing works, because otherwise every unfamiliar word will start looking like a criminal.

LESSON HANDOUT

The Three Ways Truth Gets Paraphrased

You do not need to become technical and start classifying everything in the exam hall. But you should know how paraphrasing works, because otherwise every unfamiliar word will start looking like a criminal.

1. Surface Paraphrase

This is the simplest kind. One word or a small set of words is replaced with another, while the meaning stays the same.

- **Statement:** Gejo has been teaching for the past 25 years.
- **Possible paraphrase:** Gejo has been teaching for the **last** 25 years.

"Past" becomes "last". Same idea. No problem. You could even imagine:

- teaching ➔ **instructing**: teaching ➔ **educating**
  Again, same idea. Different wording. That is a surface paraphrase.

2. Structural Paraphrase

Here the wording may remain largely similar, but the structure changes.

- **Statement:** Gejo has been teaching for the past 25 years.
- **Possible paraphrase:** For the past 25 years, Gejo has been teaching.

Same idea. Different structure. The order changes. The grammar changes. But the meaning remains intact. That is structural paraphrase.

3. Conceptual Paraphrase

This is where students begin sweating for no reason.

- **Statement:** Gejo has been teaching for the past 25 years.
- **Possible paraphrase:** Gejo has 25 years of teaching **experience**.

Now this is no longer just changing one word. This is conceptually re-expressing the same idea. If someone has been teaching for 25 years, then that person has 25 years of teaching experience. **That is conceptual paraphrase.** And yes, this is often the dangerous one.

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Do Not Get Stuck in Labels

You are not required to sit in the exam and say: *"Sir, this is structural paraphrase with slight conceptual drift."* **Relax.** The labels are only for training. Your real question is just this: **Is the idea in the option the same as the idea in the passage?**

If yes, it is truth. That's it.

The Real Test: What Must a Valid Paraphrase Preserve?

A valid paraphrase must preserve two things:

1. **Scope**
2. **Strength**

That is the heart of the lesson. If scope is damaged, the option goes wrong. If strength is damaged, the option goes wrong. If both are damaged, the option dies even faster.

Scope = Boundary

Scope means the boundaries of the claim. Has the option stayed within what the passage actually says? Or has it become broader, narrower, or shifted elsewhere? **A correct paraphrase respects the original boundary.**

Strength = Intensity

Strength means the force of the claim. Has the option preserved how strongly the passage says something? Or has it made it softer, stronger, harsher, more dramatic, more definite? **A correct paraphrase respects the original intensity.**

So whenever truth is paraphrased properly, the option must preserve:

- ✓ The boundary
- ✓ The intensity

Connection with S.T.E.A.L.S.

The wrong options you have already begun to study can usually be explained through distortions of scope or strength.

- **Scope** = boundary problem
- **Tone** = strength problem
- **Extreme** = usually both boundary and strength damaged
- **Alien** = idea not present at all
- **Lie** = direct contradiction
- **Sidetrack** = may be true, but does not answer the question

The foundation underneath them is this: **Truth must preserve scope and strength.**

Alien Words are Not Alien Ideas

This is the place where students set fire to their own accuracy. An option uses unfamiliar words. Student panics. Student says: *"Alien!"* **This is a problem.** An alien word is *not* the same thing as an alien idea. A paraphrase may introduce new words. That is perfectly normal. What matters is not whether the words are new. What matters is whether the **idea** is new.

Different vocabulary does **not** automatically mean different meaning. That is the learning.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Passage

We all know that economic theories affect government policies regarding taxes, welfare spending, interest rates and

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The Passage

We all know that economic theories affect government policies regarding taxes, welfare spending, interest rates and labour market regulations, which in turn affect our daily material lives by influencing our jobs, working conditions, wages and the repayment burdens on our mortgages or student loans. Economic theories also shape the long-term collective prospects of an economy by influencing policies that determine its abilities to engage in high-productivity industries, to innovate, and to develop in an environmentally sustainable way. But beyond even that: economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.

— *Source: "The empty basket", Ha-Joon Chang, Aeon Essays*

What is the key idea here?

Let's not get lost in the details. The passage begins by saying economics affects policy. Policy affects daily material life. Economics also shapes long-term collective prospects. Fine.

But the real punch comes at the end: **Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.** That is the line that matters. That is the truth the Question Setter will want to reward.

Now the question is: **How can this truth appear in an option?**

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LESSON HANDOUT

LESSON HANDOUT

Forensic Walkthrough: Examples of Paraphrasing

Example 1: Surface Paraphrase

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** Economics does more than shape economic indicators, whether individual or societal; it alters who we are.

Look at the changes:

- doesn't just influence ➔ **does more than shape**
- economic variables ➔ **economic indicators**
- personal ➔ **individual**
- collective ➔ **societal**
- changes ➔ **alters**

Different words everywhere. **So what?** The idea is still intact. The option does not go beyond the passage. The intensity is also intact.

This is a correct paraphrase.

Example 2: Surface Paraphrase with a Caution

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** Beyond affecting personal and collective economic forces, economics transforms us as individuals.

Now you may pause at the word ***transforms***. Fair.
But think carefully. If economics *"changes who we are"*, that is already a strong claim. So *"transforms us as individuals"* is still close enough in force. **This remains acceptable.**

But now imagine the option had said: Economics enhances us as individuals.
Now we have a problem. Why? Because *"change"* is neutral.
A change can be positive, negative, mixed, ugly, glorious, whatever. But *"enhance"* is clearly positive.
That is not paraphrase. That is distortion. That introduces an alien value judgement.

Example 3: Structural Paraphrase

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** Who we are is shaped by economics itself.

This is absolutely fine. The sentence structure has changed. The idea has not.
Same truth. Scope intact. Strength intact. **So this survives.**

LESSON HANDOUT

Example 4: Structural + Surface Paraphrase

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** Economic variables are not the only things influenced by economics; our very identity is shaped by it as well.

Again, perfectly fine. *"Changes who we are"* becomes *"our very identity is shaped by it."* That is not a new idea. That is a re-expression of the same idea. **Identity belongs inside "who we are".** So this works.

Example 5: Conceptual Paraphrase

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** *Economics shapes not only external material arrangements but also the very character of human*

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Example 5: Conceptual Paraphrase

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** *Economics shapes not only external material arrangements but also the very character of human existence.*

This is where students start behaving as though the option has committed a crime. "External material arrangements"? "Character of human existence"? What is all this, sir?

Calm down. Look at the actual idea. The passage talks about material lives, economic variables, and personal and collective consequences, and then says economics changes who we are. So if the option says economics shapes not only external material arrangements but also the very character of human existence, **that is indeed a conceptual paraphrase of the same idea.** The wording is more abstract. But abstract is not **wrong**. The option still remains inside the original claim.

Example 6: The Deadly One

- **Original:** Economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.
- **Option:** Economics is formative of the human subject, not just economic outcomes.

This is the kind of option that makes students stare at the screen and mutter dark things. What does "formative" even mean? What is "the human subject"?

Good question. **But that is not enough to eliminate it.**
"Formative" means shaping what a person becomes, and "human subject" refers to the person. The option is still aligned with: *It changes who we are.*

So again, the presence of unfamiliar words is not proof of an alien idea. It may simply be **conceptual paraphrase**. And this is why conceptual paraphrases can be deadly. They sound alien, but they are not.

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LESSON HANDOUT

What Should You Do in the Exam?

When an option sounds strange, do *not* eliminate it just because it feels unfamiliar. Instead, ask:

1. **Does it preserve the scope?** Has it stayed within the original boundary?
2. **Does it preserve the strength?** Has it maintained the same intensity?

If both are intact, the option is still alive. And if you are stuck between two options and cannot find a clear flaw, **do not sit there trying to solve philosophy inside CAT.** Move on. That button called **Next** has saved many lives. Because sometimes the better move is not *"I must fully resolve this abstract conceptual conflict right now."* The better move is: *"Let me keep this alive and see the others collapse."* **That is exam intelligence.**

Final Takeaway

The truth in the passage and the truth in the option do *not* need to have the same words. They need to have the **same idea**. And a valid paraphrased truth must preserve **scope** and **strength**. If either is distorted, the option stops being a paraphrased truth and becomes one of the traps you are learning to kill.

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 2.2: The Implies Truth

In the previous lesson, we looked at **Paraphrased Truth**. There, the truth was present in the option, but it appeared in different words, a different structure, or even at a different level of abstraction. The words changed. The idea did not.

Now we move to the second type: **Implied Truth**.

This lesson is important because this is where many students start overcomplicating simple things. They hear words like *inference* and *assumption* and immediately imagine something deeply hidden, mysterious, and floating somewhere between the lines, waiting to be excavated like an archaeological relic.

No. Let us keep this clean.

LESSON HANDOUT

What is an inference

When a question asks what can be inferred from the passage, your mind should *not* go into some dramatic mode. It should simply ask: **What is true based on the passage?**

That is all. If something is true based on the passage, it can be inferred from the passage. That is the easiest and most useful way to look at inference in Reading Comprehension.

DO NOT get trapped in this silly confusion:

- → inference must be unstated
- → inference must be hidden
- → inference must be deep
- → inference must not be directly visible

None of that is necessary. If it is true based on the passage, it is an inference. **That is the standard.**

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The simplest way to look at inference is this: **If a statement is true, then what else must also be true?**
That is inference.

- ❌ Inference is not fantasy.
- ❌ Inference is not "This sounds possible."
- ❌ Inference is not "I can imagine this."
- ❌ Inference is not "Maybe the author wanted to say this."

Inference in RC means a **valid truth** that follows from what is given. That word *valid* matters. Because in real life, people make bad inferences all the time. Two people are walking down the street holding hands. Someone instantly concludes that they must be boyfriend and girlfriend. Could be true. Could also be nonsense.
That is **not** the kind of inference RC wants from you. RC wants valid inferences.

Pro-tip: From now on, whenever you see: *"Which of the following can be inferred from the passage?"*, translate it in your head as: **"Which of the following is true based on the passage?"** That move alone will clean up a lot of confusion.

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LESSON HANDOUT

What is an Assumption?

The word *assumption* also creates unnecessary panic. Again, students imagine something hidden and invisible and complicated.

Keep it simple. An assumption is: **Something necessary for a statement to make sense or be true.** That is

LESSON HANDOUT

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Keep it simple. An assumption is: **Something necessary for a statement to make sense or be true.** That is all.

For example, if I say: *"This is a square."*
What all must be true for that statement to hold?
✓ It must have four sides.
✓ Those sides must be equal.
✓ It must be a closed figure.
✓ Its internal angles must be 90°.

These are assumptions built into the statement.
Or suppose A tells B: *"Go to the market and buy vegetables."*
What all must be true for this to make sense?
→ The market must exist.
→ Vegetables must exist.
→ Buying must be possible.
→ Going must be possible.
→ It must be possible for B to go to the market.
→ Vegetables must be available there.

These are assumptions. They are not random extras. They are truths **necessary** for the statement to stand.
Remember:

- **Inference** = what is true *because* of the statement
- **Assumption** = what must be true *for* the statement to make sense

That is the difference.

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LESSON HANDOUT

THE IMPLIED TRUTHS

LESSON HANDOUT

THE IMPLIED TRUTHS

When we deal with **Implied Truth**, we are usually dealing with three broad possibilities:

1. Immediate Valid Inference
2. Combined Valid Inference
3. Necessary Assumption

Do not get lost in the labels. These are only to help you understand how truth can appear. At the end of the day, all three are still part of the same family: **truth based on the passage.**

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A Small Example Before the Passage

Let us take two simple statements:

1. *Gejo has been teaching for the past 25 years.*
2. *Someone with more than 10 years of teaching experience is bound to have strong expertise in the subject that they teach.*

1. Immediate Valid Inference

Take the second statement: *"Someone with more than 10 years of teaching experience is bound to have strong expertise..."*

What must be true if this statement is true?

→ **It is not possible for someone with 15 years of teaching experience to be weak in the subject that they teach.**

Why? Because 15 years is more than 10 years. And the statement says anyone with more than 10 is bound to have strong expertise. This follows immediately.

2. Combined Valid Inference

Now combine both statements. If Gejo has been teaching for 25 years, and anyone with more than 10 years has strong expertise, then this must be true:

→ **Gejo has strong expertise in the subject he teaches.**

It is not directly written, but it is definitely true if both statements are true.

3. Necessary Assumption

Now ask this: What must be true for the second statement itself to make sense?

→ **Length of teaching experience reliably produces subject expertise.**

If that is not assumed, the original statement collapses. On what basis are you claiming that more than 10 years guarantees expertise? This is a necessary assumption.

Negation Test to check assumptions:

How do we check whether something is truly necessary? Simple. **Negate it.** If denying it destroys the original statement, then the assumption was necessary.

Take this assumption: *"Length of teaching experience reliably produces subject expertise."* **Now deny it:** *"Length of teaching experience **does not** reliably produce subject expertise."*

What happens? The original statement that 10+ years guarantees expertise **collapses**. So the assumption was necessary. That is the logic of the **Negation Test** or **Denial Test**.

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The Passage

What happens? The original statement that 10+ years guarantees expertise **collapses**. So the assumption was necessary. That is the logic of the **Negation Test** or **Denial Test.**

LESSON HANDOUT

The Passage

We all know that economic theories affect government policies regarding taxes, welfare spending, interest rates and labour market regulations, which in turn affect our daily material lives by influencing our jobs, working conditions, wages and the repayment burdens on our mortgages or student loans. Economic theories also shape the long-term collective prospects of an economy by influencing policies that determine its abilities to engage in high-productivity industries, to innovate, and to develop in an environmentally sustainable way. But beyond even that: economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.

— Source: "The Empty Basket", Ha-Joon Chang, Aeon Essays

The broad movement of the passage

1. Economic theories affect policy.
2. Policy affects material life and collective prospects.
3. Economics goes beyond all this and **changes who we are.**

Immediate Valid Inferences: DETAILED Forensics

An immediate valid inference comes from a specific statement. You take that statement, assume it is true, and ask: *"What else must also be true?"*

From Sentence 1

Sentence: We all know that economic theories affect government policies regarding taxes, welfare spending, interest rates and labour market regulations, which in turn affect our daily material lives by influencing our jobs, working conditions, wages and the repayment burdens on our mortgages or student loans.

Immediate Inferences:

"Changes in economic theory can lead to changes in people's jobs, wages and financial burdens."

Logic: The passage establishes a causal chain:

Theory ⇨ Policy ⇨ Daily Life (jobs, wages, loans).

If you change the first domino (Theory), the last domino (Wages) must eventually fall. Therefore, a shift in how we *think* about economics has the power to change how much is in your bank account.

"Economic theories have practical consequences, not merely academic significance."

Logic: If these theories reach into your "working conditions" and your "student loans," they aren't just abstract equations on a chalkboard. They have *teeth*. They are practical because they dictate the material reality of your life.

"Government policy acts as a transmission mechanism between theory and daily life."

Logic: Theory doesn't touch your wages directly. It touches *policy* (taxes, interest rates), and *policy* touches you. Policy is the "middle-man" or the gear that transfers the energy of a theory into the movement of daily life.

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From Sentence 2

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From Sentence 2

Sentence: Economic theories also shape the long-term collective prospects of an economy by influencing policies that determine its abilities to engage in high-productivity industries, to innovate, and to develop in an environmentally sustainable way.

Immediate Inferences:

"The future trajectory of an economy depends partly on the dominant economic theories guiding policy."
Logic: The passage says theories shape "long-term collective prospects." This is just a fancy way of saying "future trajectory." Since it "influences" these prospects, the future is *dependent* on the theories. Note the word **partly**—it respects the scope because the author doesn't claim theory is the *only* factor.

"Policy decisions influence whether an economy becomes innovative or stagnant."
Logic: The text explicitly states that policies determine an economy's ability to "innovate." If policy determines the ability to innovate, it by definition influences the opposite state—stagnation.

"Economic theories influence how well an economy and its people will fare in the future."

Logic: "Long-term collective prospects" is a direct synonym for "faring in the future." If the prospects are shaped by theory, then the well-being (faring) of the collective (economy and people) is influenced by those theories.

From Sentence 3

Sentence: But beyond even that: economics doesn't just influence economic variables, whether personal or collective. It changes who we are.

Immediate Inferences:

"There are non-economic dimensions affected by economics."
Logic: The author contrasts "economic variables" with "who we are." Since "who we are" (identity/self) is not a financial variable like an interest rate, it represents a non-economic dimension. If economics changes *that*, it has breached the boundary of pure finance.

"Economics has cultural consequences, not merely financial ones."
Logic: Identity and self-perception are cultural and psychological constructs. By stating that economics "changes who we are," the author is admitting that the impact of economics is felt in the culture of the self, not just in the wallet.

"The way a society embraces an economic framework impacts how people see themselves in that economy."
Logic: If economics changes "who we are," then the specific "economic framework" or theory a society chooses will dictate the *kind* of person someone becomes or how they perceive their own identity within that system.

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Combined Valid Inferences

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LESSON HANDOUT

Combined Valid Inferences

"Economics is not just descriptive. It is performative."
Logic: Put it all together. It doesn't just "describe" the world; it *shapes* policy, *alters* daily life, and *changes* identity. It *performs* a role in creating reality.

"Economics is a force that moulds both the external world and the inner world of human beings."
Logic: External = policies, wages, sustainability. Inner = "who we are." The passage covers both territories.

"Changes in dominant economic thinking can alter both society's future trajectory and the citizen's sense of self."
Logic: Combines the "long-term prospects" of sentence 2 with the "changes who we are" of sentence 3.

Necessary Assumptions

Assumption 1: The influence of economic theory on policy is sufficiently evident.
Logic: The author begins with the phrase, *"We all know that..."* You don't start an essay with "We all know" unless you assume the link between theory and policy is visible, recognised, and accepted by the audience. If the influence of theory were hidden or non-existent, the author could not confidently present this as a starting fact.

Assumption 2: Government policies are created at least partly by incorporating economic theories.
Logic: The passage claims theories "affect" policies. This requires a functional relationship where theory is actually an ingredient in the policy-making process. If policies were made purely by random whim or "luck" without any theoretical basis, the author's causal chain would be a lie.

Assumption 3: Policies can impact the long-term prospects of an economy.
Logic: Sentence 2 says theories shape prospects *by influencing policies*. This only works if policies themselves have the power to shape the future. If policies were toothless or irrelevant to the long-term economy, the author's claim that theory shapes prospects would fail.

Assumption 4: People can internalise economic logic.
Logic: The author's strongest claim is that economics *"changes who we are."* For this to be true, the human "self" must be a sponge that can absorb and be shaped by economic structures. If humans were biologically immune to external logic, economics couldn't change our identity.

Assumption 5: Identity can be socially constructed.
Logic: This is the bedrock. The author assumes identity is fluid and shaped by environmental factors like economics. If identity were fixed at birth and unchangeable by society, the final sentence—the heart of the argument—would be impossible.

Logic: The author's strongest claim is that economics *"changes who we are."* For this to be true, the human "self" must be a sponge that can absorb and be shaped by economic structures. If humans were biologically immune to external logic, economics couldn't change our identity.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Do Not Get Lost in Naming the Truth

In the exam hall, you are not required to classify every option. Nobody cares. These labels are for training. Your job is only this: **Is this true based on the passage?**

How should you check that truth?

Exactly the way we have already learnt. Ask:

- ❌ Is there a real **Scope** problem?
- ❌ Is there a real **Tone** problem?
- ❌ Is there an **Extreme** distortion?
- ❌ Is there an actual **Alien** idea?
- ❌ Is there a **Lie**?
- ❌ Is this a **Sidetrack** (true but irrelevant)?

Truth does not need to be copied from the passage. It only needs to remain faithful to the passage.

Another clean way to think about Inference and Assumption

Suppose a speaker says something.

- **Inference:** What follows from the statement? (What is the *result*?).
- **Assumption:** What must already be true for the statement to stand? (What is the *foundation*?).

Why This Lesson Matters

This lesson is teaching you how **flexible** truth can be inside answer options. The correct option may appear as:

- → a direct paraphrase
- → an immediate inference
- → a combined inference
- → a necessary assumption

Once you understand that, you stop depending on superficial word-matching. You stop panicking when the wording changes. You stop treating unfamiliar words as proof of an alien idea. Then, distortions like Scope or Tone become easier to spot.

Lesson Takeaway

1. **Inference in RC simply means:** truth based on the passage.
2. **Assumption means:** something necessary for the statement to make sense.
3. **Implied truth can appear in three forms:** Immediate Inference, Combined Inference, or Necessary Assumption.
4. **Do not get trapped in whether something is stated or unstated. Check whether it is true.**

Final Takeaway

Just because an option does not repeat the passage does not mean it is wrong. Truth can be implied. Your job is not to hunt for copied sentences; it is to **recognise valid truth.**

LESSON HANDOUT

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 3.1: DISTORTION – Scope Error

The Spectrum: From Truth to the Absolute Lie

Before we kill the options, we need to understand how they are engineered. Think of every option as a point on a spectrum of **logical validity.**

- **The Pure Truth (The Anchor):** This is the idea established in the passage. It is the "Sacred Boundary." The correct option will always stay within this fence.
- **The Truth Converter Machine:** This is how the correct answer is born. It takes the *soul* of the passage and gives it *new clothes*. It uses different words (paraphrases truths) or logical consequences/implications (implied truths), but it **never** violates the boundary.
- **The Distortion (The Funhouse Mirror):** This is where most students die. A distortion isn't necessarily a "lie." It's often a version of the truth that has been twisted, stretched, or squeezed. It *smells* like the passage, but it is fundamentally unfaithful.

The **S.T.E.A.L.S.** framework is your forensic kit to catch these distortions:

- **S**cope Error (Our focus today)
- **T**one Mismatch
- **E**xtreme Position
- **A**lien Idea
- **L**ie
- **S**idetrack

LESSON HANDOUT

What Exactly is Scope?

Scope is simply **The Boundary.** Imagine the author has built a beautiful, small garden. They are talking about *this* specific rose in *this* specific corner.

- **Scope Broadening** is like claiming the author is talking about every rose in the entire world.
- **Scope Narrowing** is like claiming the author is *only* talking about the left-most petal of that specific rose.

Both are **Rotten.** Why? Because the passage does not provide enough evidence for the "Broad" claim, and it doesn't give you permission to "Narrow" the claim to only one tiny subset.

Why Scope Error is More Dangerous than an Alien Idea

An **Alien Idea** is easy to spot. It's a stranger at the party. If the passage is about whales and the option talks about space stations, you kill it instantly.

But a **Scope Error** is a guest from the invite list who has wandered into the wrong room. It uses the same

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An **Alien Idea** is easy to spot. It's a stranger at the party. If the passage is about whales and the option talks about space stations, you kill it instantly.

But a **Scope Error** is a guest from the invite list who has wandered into the wrong room. It uses the same keywords as the passage. It uses the same characters. It feels "intellectual." But it quietly stretches the claim until it snaps.

The Two Crimes of Scope

1. Scope Broadening

This happens when an option takes a limited, local truth and inflates it into a general theory or a global phenomenon.

- **Example:** If the passage says, "Some residents in this building were unhappy," the trap will say, "The city is facing a crisis of dissatisfaction."
- **Logic:** You've taken a "some" and made it "to a larger group". You've taken a "building" and made it a "city." The author has no authority over the city based on this text.

2. Scope Narrowing

This happens when the author makes a broad point, but the option tries to restrict it to one specific group or one specific instance mentioned in the text.

- **Example:** If the passage says, "Modern technology has changed how humans communicate," the trap will say, "Smartphones have changed how teenagers talk to their parents."
- **Logic:** While technically "true" that smartphones and teenagers are involved, the passage was about *all* humans and *all* technology. By narrowing it, you are ignoring the larger point the author established.

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The Passage:

You want to spend less time on your phone. But what is the best way to slash your screen time? The internet (ironically) has some ideas: chain your mobile to the wall; print out your Instagram feed on dozens of pieces of paper; or practise "appstinence" by ditching the device for long stretches.

The latest method to go viral promises a more concrete solution: youngsters are turning to the Brick, an app-blocking device. . . . The grey cube, which costs $59 and is about the size of an AirPods case, claims to reduce screen time by three hours a day on average. To use the device, you choose the apps you would like to disable and touch your phone to the "brick". When you are ready, you can tap your phone against it to "unbrick".

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There is a paradox at the heart of the current trend, however. Gen Z may have declared 2026 "the year of analogue", but they have done this on TikTok. The Brick has gone viral on social media. . . . Perhaps that is why most digital detoxes fail: people are quickly drawn back to screens and apps.

However, many say the Brick is the best tool they have tried yet. The secret is to place "distractions out of reach", says Thomas Driver, the company's co-founder: "Temptation is sidelined until you physically return to the Brick." In a digital world, this bricks-and-mortar approach has merits.

— Source: Addicted to your phone? Try "bricking" it, The Economist

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The Boundary Map (The Fence)

Before we look at the traps, look at what is *actually* in the garden:

1. **The Problem:** Universal desire for less screen time.
2. **The Context:** Bizarre internet hacks exist (chaining phones, etc.).
3. **The Focus:** A specific device called "The Brick."
4. **The Observation:** The irony of using social media to promote an anti-social-media tool.
5. **The Conclusion:** Physical distancing is a legitimate psychological strategy.

Anything outside this is a trespasser.

LESSON HANDOUT

Walkthrough: The Example Sets

Example Set 1: Virality and Social Media

Passage Extract: *The latest method to go viral promises a more concrete solution: youngsters are turning to the Brick, an app-blocking device. . . .*

The Truth (Converted): *The Brick has gained significant public interest through digital platforms.*

Logic: This is a **valid paraphrase**. "Significant public interest" is a truth-converted version of "gone viral." "Digital platforms" is a safe umbrella term for "social media." This option stays perfectly inside the fence.

Scope Error – Broadening: *The popularity of the Brick indicates a global movement against smartphone addiction.*

Logic: "Viral on social media" does **not** equal a "global movement." Virality is a trend; a movement is a coordinated, organised social shift. Furthermore, "smartphone addiction" is a heavy, clinical diagnosis. The passage only discusses wanting to "spend less time" on phones. This option inflates a local trend into a worldwide revolution.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *A small group of Gen Z influencers is experimenting with a physical app-blocking device.*

Logic: The passage says the device went "viral." Virality implies a mass, broad audience, not just a "small group." While Gen Z is mentioned as the group declaring the "year of analogue," restricting the entire phenomenon of the Brick to only "influencers" and only a "small group" unfairly squeezes the author's claim.

Example Set 2: Internet Suggestions

Passage Extract: *The internet (ironically) has some ideas: chain your mobile to the wall; print out your Instagram feed on dozens of pieces of paper; or practise "appstinence" by ditching the device for long stretches.*

The Truth (Converted): *Online communities propose various unconventional strategies for reducing device dependency.*

Logic: "Online communities" = "The Internet." "Unconventional strategies" = "Chaining your phone to the wall." This is a valid paraphrase that preserves the boundary.

Scope Error – Broadening: *Screen-time reduction has generated a range of organised, institutional responses.*

Logic: Chaining your phone to a wall or printing your Instagram feed are *scattered, bizarre hacks*. They are the opposite of "organised, institutional responses." This makes the situation sound like a government policy or a formal programme. The author never suggests these ideas are coordinated or formal.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *TikTok is the primary platform used to promote unconventional strategies for digital detoxing.*

Logic: The passage says "the internet" has ideas. TikTok is only mentioned later in a specific paradox about Gen Z and the Brick. We cannot take the "internet's" ideas and narrow them down to a single "primary platform" called TikTok.

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Example Set 3: Digital Detox Failure

Passage Extract: *Perhaps that is why most digital detoxes fail: people are quickly drawn back to screens and apps.*

The Truth (Converted): *The difficulty of resisting digital impulses often leads to the failure of attempts to withdraw from technology.*

Logic: "Difficulty of resisting impulses" = "People are drawn back." "Attempts to withdraw" = "Digital detoxes."

Logic: Chaining your phone to a wall or printing your Instagram feed are *scattered, bizarre hacks*. They are the opposite of "organised, institutional responses." This makes the situation sound like a government policy or a formal programme. The author never suggests these ideas are coordinated or formal.

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The Truth (Converted): *The difficulty of resisting digital impulses often leads to the failure of attempts to withdraw from technology.*

Logic: "Difficulty of resisting impulses" = "People are drawn back." "Attempts to withdraw" = "Digital detoxes." This preserves both the scope and the strength of the original claim.

Scope Error – Broadening: *Modern society is inherently incapable of sustaining a lifestyle independent of digital tools.*

Logic: The author said "most detoxes fail" because people like apps. They did **not** declare a civilisational death sentence for "modern society." This is a sweeping, philosophical diagnosis that the text doesn't support. It turns a local failure into a universal law.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *Young users frequently abandon their appstinence goals due to peer pressure on social media.*

Logic: Where is "peer pressure" in the text? Nowhere. That's an **Alien Idea** mixed with **Narrowing.** The passage says they are "drawn back" by the apps themselves, not necessarily by peers. Furthermore, the passage says "people" detoxes fail, not just "young users."

Example Set 4: The "Bricks-and-Mortar" Value

Passage Extract: *In a digital world, this bricks-and-mortar approach has merits.*

The Truth (Converted): *In a digital environment, non-digital interventions may have value.*

Logic: "Digital environment" = "Digital world." "Non-digital interventions" = "Bricks-and-mortar approach." "May have value" = "Has merits." Perfectly preserved logic.

Scope Error – Broadening: *Physical solutions are generally more effective than digital ones in managing technology use.*

Logic: The author said the Brick "has merits." They didn't say it's "generally more effective" than everything else in existence. Don't turn a specific compliment into a general hierarchy. This is a massive broadening of a tentative, local observation.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *The bricks-and-mortar method may help Gen Z manage their screen habits.*

Logic: While Gen Z is mentioned in the passage, the author's final claim about the "bricks-and-mortar approach having merits" is a general conclusion for *anyone* in the digital world. By restricting it to only Gen Z, you are narrowing a universal takeaway into a demographic footnote.
